



UPSC CSE 2027

ANTHROPOLOGY

OPTIONAL FOUNDATION

HANDOUT 03
SOCIO-CULTURAL ANTHROPOLOGY



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7+ Years Experience

Recommended by
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SOCIO-CULTURAL ANTHROPOLOGY

Handout- 3

Syllabus covered in this handout:

Paper 1:

- **Chapter 4. Political Organization and Social Control :**
 - I. Band, tribe, chiefdom, kingdom and state;
 - II. Concepts of power, authority and legitimacy;
 - III. Social control, law and justice in simple Societies.
- **Chapter 5. Religion :**
 - I. Anthropological approaches to the study of religion (evolutionary, psychological and functional); Monotheism and polytheism;
 - II. Sacred and profane;
 - III. Myths and rituals;
 - IV. Forms of religion in tribal and peasant Societies (animism, animatism, fetishism, naturism and totemism);
 - V. Religion, magic and science distinguished;
 - VI. Magico-religious functionaries (priest, shaman, medicine man, sorcerer and witch).

Paper 1- Chapter 4

Political Organization and Social Control

4. Political Organization and Social Control :

- I. Band, tribe, chiefdom, kingdom and state;
- II. Concepts of power, authority and legitimacy;
- III. Social control, law and justice in simple Societies.

Meaning of Political Organization:

- In simple societies, political organization is informal, where authority rests with kinship groups such as families, bands, or tribes. Social control is exercised by elders, lineage heads, or collective group norms.
- In contrast, modern societies rely on both **written laws** (constitution, legal codes) and **unwritten customs** (norms, traditions). These are enforced through peaceful means such as negotiation, or coercive means such as policing and sanctions. In a state system, the organs of government hold **legitimate power** to pass laws and regulate citizens.

Political Science vs Political Anthropology:

- **Political Science** studies politics in a formal sense, focusing on the state, constitutions, government, and power relations at a national or international level. It is normative and institutional in orientation.
- **Political Anthropology**, by contrast, is cross-cultural and holistic. It studies political institutions in all human societies, whether or not they have a state. _____ defined political anthropology as the study of how authority, law, and order are maintained in stateless as well as centralized societies. **Morton Fried (1967)** and **Elman Service (1962)** provided evolutionary models of political systems, highlighting the transition from egalitarian bands to stratified states.

Scope of Political Anthropology:

- **Forms of Political Organization:**
 - Political anthropology examines societies ranging from stateless to centralized systems.
 - _____ proposed four types – bands, tribes, chiefdoms, and states, each with different degrees of hierarchy and centralization.
 - _____ refined this by distinguishing between egalitarian, ranked, and stratified societies. This evolutionary framework helps explain how social complexity and inequality arise.
- **Power, Authority, and Legitimacy:**
 - Political anthropology analyses how societies define and distribute authority.
 - _____ identified three pure types of legitimate authority – traditional, charismatic, and rational-legal, which are still applied in anthropological case studies.
 - For instance, the **traditional authority** of Polynesian chiefs illustrate how legitimacy is culturally embedded.
- **Kinship and Politics:**
 - In many tribal societies, kinship regulates access to authority.



- **Evans-Pritchard (1940)** showed that among the Nuer of Sudan, political order was maintained through **segmentary lineage systems**, without centralized leadership.
- Kinship thus acts as a political framework, resolving disputes and maintaining balance of power.
- **Mechanisms of Social Control:**
 - Anthropologists study both **formal** (courts, councils, laws) and **informal** (customs, taboos, religion) controls.
 - **Malinowski (1926, *Crime and Custom in Savage Society*)** demonstrated that law in “primitive” societies is embedded in reciprocity and mutual obligations rather than codified rules.
 - Political anthropology shows how small-scale societies regulate behavior without state coercion.
- **Law, Justice, and Custom:**
 - A major concern is how rules are created, interpreted, and enforced. Anthropologists distinguish between “law in the books” and “law in action.”
 - For example, customary law in African tribal courts operates differently than Western legal systems, emphasizing restoration and community harmony rather than punitive justice.
- **Conflict and Conflict Resolution:**
 - Political anthropology investigates how disputes arise and are resolved.
 - **Max Gluckman (1955)** studied tribal courts in Barotse society and argued that conflict can reinforce rather than weaken social order.
 - Through case studies, anthropologists highlight how communities use negotiation, compensation, or ritual to prevent escalation of disputes.

Relevance of Political Anthropology:

- **Understanding Diversity:**
 - Political anthropology helps in understanding the diverse ways in which different societies organize and manage their political systems. It provides insights into the variety of political structures, from stateless societies to complex state formations, and how these systems adapt to their cultural and environmental contexts.
 - In the context of indigenous societies, the ongoing struggle for land rights and sovereignty among the Maasai in Tanzania exemplifies the diversity of political structures as they contend with the Tanzanian government's policies on land use and conservation.
- **Cultural Context of Politics:**
 - Political anthropology emphasizes the importance of cultural context in shaping political beliefs, practices, and institutions. It helps in unraveling the symbolic and cultural dimensions of political systems, shedding light on how cultural values influence political decision-making.
 - The Standing Rock protests in the United States showcased the cultural context of indigenous political resistance, where Native American communities opposed the construction of the Dakota Access Pipeline, emphasizing the intertwined nature of cultural and political values.
- **Globalization and its impact on simple societies:**
 - In the era of globalization, political anthropology is crucial for understanding how global forces interact with local political structures. It explores the impact of transnational processes on local communities, examining issues such as migration, identity politics, and the spread of ideologies across borders.
 - The impact of globalization on indigenous communities is evident in the struggles of the Amazon rainforest's indigenous populations against deforestation and resource extraction, as global economic forces intersect with local political structures in countries like Brazil.
- **Conflict and Cooperation:**
 - Political anthropology contributes to the understanding of conflict and cooperation within and between societies. It investigates the causes and resolutions of conflicts, as well as the mechanisms that promote social cohesion and cooperation.
 - The conflict over resource extraction in Canada, such as the protests against the Coastal GasLink pipeline by Wet'suwet'en First Nation, illustrates how indigenous communities engage in both conflict and cooperation to protect their land and rights.

The scope and relevance of political anthropology extend far beyond the study of states and governments. By comparing political systems across cultures, it shows how power, authority, and legitimacy are embedded in kinship, ritual, law, and symbols. From **Evans-Pritchard's segmentary lineages** to **Geertz's theatre state**, from **Service's bands and tribes** to **Fried's stratified societies**, political anthropology reveals the diversity of political life. In an era of globalization, indigenous resistance, and transnational governance, it remains vital for understanding how societies manage order, resolve conflicts, and construct legitimacy in ways that are deeply cultural.



Types of Political Systems:

- A political system refers to how a society **maintains social order** and **reduces social disorder**.
- Anthropologists analyze the political structures of pre-literate societies primarily through two classifications: **State and Stateless political systems**.
- Broadly, archaeological findings indicate that states originated from **initially stateless** communities when a sizable population (typically tens of thousands) cohabited in a specific territory and engaged in agricultural practices. Notably, defending the territory emerges as a distinctive function of the state.
- Nevertheless, there are **exceptions**: **Lawrence Krader** for example describes the case of the **Tatar state**, a political authority arising among confederations of clans of nomadic or semi-nomadic herdsman.
 - **State political system:-**
 - A state is a self-governing political entity that encompasses multiple communities within its **borders**.
 - It possesses a **centralized government** empowered to levy taxes, mobilize individuals for labor or military service, and establish and enforce laws.
 - The state fulfills its functions through the government, which consists of a complex centralized political framework comprising permanent institutions like the **legislature, executive, and judiciary**.
 - In maintaining control, the government in states seeks a monopoly on the use of physical force, employing entities like the **police force and military**.
 - **Examples:** The modern nation-states and chiefdoms
 - The **Ashanti of Ghana** were organized under the **Asantehene (king)**, who commanded tribute, military power, and ritual authority, supported by a council of chiefs. Their system combined **hereditary leadership, centralized control, and redistribution of resources**, making them a classic case of a chiefdom in West Africa.



- **Stateless political system:-**
 - A stateless political system lacks formal organization, with laws relying on **oral tradition and customs** instead of written documentation.
 - Punishments serve as deterrents, potentially extending beyond the individual to include their kin.
 - Evidence is not solely reliant on witnesses but also involves **oaths and ordeals**.
 - Magic and religion play significant roles in various aspects of life within stateless political systems.
 - Eg: **band and tribal political organizations**– It has the **sense of collective responsibilities rather than individual's rights and privileges**.
 - Among the **Nuer of South Sudan** (_____), political order is maintained through **segmentary lineage organization**, where kinship ties regulate alliances and disputes are settled by lineage elders without centralized authority.
 - Similarly, the **Inuit of Arctic regions** rely on **public opinion, ridicule, and community pressure** rather than codified law, with conflicts resolved through mediation or even song duels.
- **Difference between State and Stateless societies:**

Feature	State societies	Stateless societies
Political organization	Centralized hierarchical	Decentralized and egalitarian
Social Stratification	High social stratification	Little to no social stratification

Feature	State societies	Stateless societies
Territory	Occupies a defined territory	Does not occupy a defined territory
Legal system	Has a formal legal system	Does not have a formal legal system
Authority	Authority is held by a centralized government or state	Authority is not held by a centralized government or state
Defense	Has a centralized system of defense	Does not have a centralized system of defense

State societies institutionalize **centralized authority, laws, taxation, and defense**, while stateless societies rely on **kinship, customs, and collective responsibility** (Fortes & Evans-Pritchard, 1940). The contrast highlights how cultural and ecological contexts shape the evolution of political organization.

- **Egalitarian and Non-Egalitarian societies:**

The study of social organization in anthropology often contrasts **egalitarian** and **non-egalitarian (stratified)** societies. Elman Service (1962) in *Primitive Social Organization* classified societies into bands, tribes, chiefdoms, and states, where bands and many tribes are largely egalitarian. Morton Fried (1967) in *The Evolution of Political Society* refined this by distinguishing egalitarian, ranked, and stratified societies, focusing on the institutionalization of inequality. These frameworks remain central to understanding how power, resources, and status are distributed in human groups.

- **Egalitarian Societies:**

- **Social Hierarchy Absence:**

- Egalitarian societies are characterized by the absence of institutionalized social classes or ranks.
 - Service described band societies such as the !Kung San or Mbuti as operating without permanent leaders.
 - Morton Fried defined egalitarian societies as those “lacking hereditary social distinctions of wealth, power, or prestige.”

- **Consensus Decision-Making:**

- Leadership, if present, is situational and temporary.
 - Marshall Sahlins noted that leadership in band and tribal societies is based on personal qualities like hunting skill or oratory, but decisions require group consensus.
 - The Mbuti Pygmies studied by Colin Turnbull in *The Forest People* provide an example where disputes are resolved communally.

- **Collective Resource Ownership:**

- Richard B. Lee’s classic ethnography of the !Kung (1968) shows that hunting spoils and gathered foods are shared widely, ensuring equality and minimizing individual accumulation.
 - Land rights are generally collective or flexible rather than private.

- **Equal Power Distribution:**

- Power is dispersed among members. Fried emphasized that in egalitarian societies, authority is informal, non-coercive, and dependent on persuasion rather than force.
 - Gender, age, or skill may bring respect but not permanent hierarchical power.

- **Non-Egalitarian Societies:**

- **Presence of Social Hierarchy:**

- Non-egalitarian societies institutionalize ranking or stratification.
 - Fried distinguished between “ranked” societies (chiefdoms) and “stratified” societies (states).
 - For instance, Polynesian chiefdoms studied by Sahlins had hereditary chiefs who enjoyed ritual superiority.

- **Hierarchy or Authority in Decision-Making:**

- Authority is formalized. Weber’s typology of authority – traditional, charismatic, and rational-legal, applies more to non-egalitarian societies where leaders make decisions for others. In chiefdoms, the chief’s command carried coercive backing.

- **Private Resource Ownership:**

- Unlike collective ownership in bands, stratified societies develop private property.
 - In feudal Europe, lords controlled land and peasants had obligations. This institutionalizes economic inequality.
 - Anthropologists note that this stage coincides with the emergence of surplus and redistribution controlled by elites.



- **Unequal Power Distribution:**

- Power is concentrated.
- **Service** noted that states are marked by centralized political authority.
- Fried emphasized that stratification represents “differential access to basic resources,” where some groups consistently monopolize wealth, status, and coercive force.

The contrast between egalitarian and non-egalitarian societies illustrates how inequality emerges historically. Service’s typology shows the structural progression from bands to states, while Fried’s framework highlights the institutionalization of inequality in ranked and stratified societies. Egalitarian societies embody sharing, consensus, and flexible authority, whereas non-egalitarian ones entrench hierarchy, private ownership, and unequal power. Together, these perspectives reveal how anthropologists explain the shift from cooperative human groups to complex states with systemic inequality.

- **Difference between Egalitarian and Non-egalitarian societies:**

Feature	Egalitarian societies	Non Egalitarian societies
Social hierarchy	Lack of social hierarchy	Presence of social hierarchy
Decision-making	Decision-making is based on consensus	Decision-making is based on hierarchy or authority
Ownership of resources	Collective ownership of resources	Private ownership of resources
Power distribution	Power is distributed equally among members	Power is not distributed equally among members

Main Reasons for different types of societies:

1. Subsistence Economy (Basis of Egalitarian Societies)

- In band and tribal societies, people live by hunting, gathering, or simple horticulture. Elman Service (1962) showed that such societies produce **only what they need for immediate use**, with little or no surplus.
- Since resources are perishable and unpredictable, they are **shared collectively**. Richard Lee’s study of the !Kung demonstrated how meat from hunting is distributed to minimize inequality.
- Without surplus accumulation, there is **no scope for permanent economic or social hierarchy**. Leadership, if any, is situational and based on consensus.

2. Surplus Storage and Private Property (Basis of Non-Egalitarian Societies)

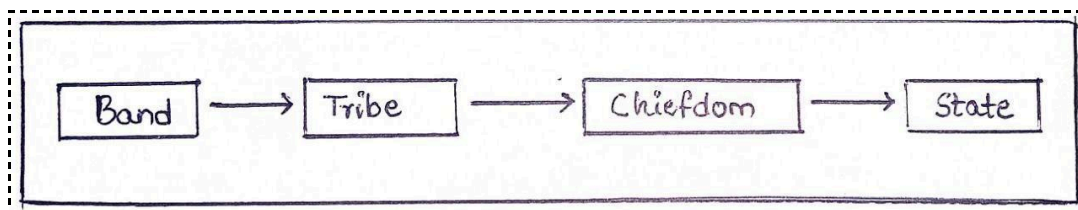
- With the advent of intensive agriculture and animal domestication, societies began producing **surplus beyond subsistence needs**. Morton Fried (1967) argued that surplus leads to **control and redistribution by certain individuals or groups**, creating ranked and stratified societies.
- Surplus enables **private ownership of land and resources**, as seen in chiefdoms of Polynesia (studied by Sahlins) or agrarian states in Mesopotamia.
- This marks the beginning of **economic inequality, hereditary leadership, and institutionalized social classes**.

The key difference lies in the **economic base**. Subsistence economies foster egalitarian societies where sharing ensures survival. Surplus economies create the conditions for private property, accumulation, and stratification, leading to non-egalitarian societies.

I. Development of political system:

Political organizations refer to groups that exist for the purpose of public **decision making** and **leadership**, maintaining **social cohesion and order**, **protecting group rights**, and ensuring **safety from external threats**.

Anthropologist **Elman Service** (1962) listed four types or levels of political organizations: **band**, **tribe**, **chiefdom** and **state**. Although Service’s classification does not fit for all societies, it is a useful way to show how societies vary in trying to create and maintain social order.



	Total numbers	Social Organisation	Economic Organisation	Major forms of Distribution	Settlement Patterns	Religious Organisation	Architecture	Recent or Contemporary Examples
Band	less than 100	egalitarian, informal leadership	mobile hunter gatherers	Reciprocity	temporary camps	shamans	temporary shelters	Australian Aborigines
Tribe	upto a few thousand	segmentary possibly made up of several "bands", leaders lack economic control.	settled farmers, pastoralists, herders	Reciprocity	permanent villages, no one settlement dominates others	religious elders, calendrical rituals	permanent huts, burial mounds, shrines	New Guinea Highlanders
Chiefdom	5000-20,000	kinship based ranking, hereditary leaders, leaders control some or all aspects of trade.	central accumulation and redistribution, prestige goods, craft specialization.	Reciprocity and Redistribution	fortified centres, ritual centres	hereditary chief with ritual duties	large scale monuments	18th century Polynesian chiefdoms
State	generally 20,000+	class based hierarchy	centralized bureaucracy, tribute, taxation, laws	Market Exchange	urban cities, towns, frontier defenses, roads	priestly class, pantheistic or monotheistic religion	palaces, temples and other public buildings	modern states

Extra Material for reference:

1. Band-Level Political Organization

Bands are the **simplest form of political organization**, typically associated with hunting and gathering societies. **Elman Service (1962)** categorized them as the earliest stage of political evolution. They are small, kin-based, egalitarian groups with informal leadership.

Main Features

- Population and Composition**
 - Usually 20–100 people.
 - Membership is flexible; mobility is high.
 - Tied together by **kinship and marriage networks**.
- Leadership**
 - Informal and situational; no permanent leader.
 - Leaders emerge based on skill (hunting, healing, oratory).
 - Described as **"first among equals"** (Service).
- Decision-Making**
 - Based on **consensus**, not coercion.
 - Important matters: migration, hunting, food sharing, conflict settlement.
- Conflict Resolution**
 - Avoidance, ridicule, or leaving the group are common.
 - Oaths and supernatural beliefs sometimes invoked.
- Social Stratification**
 - Absent**; equality in access to resources.
 - Marshall Sahlins (1972)** called bands "egalitarian societies" where reciprocity sustains harmony.
- Economic Base**
 - Hunting, gathering, fishing.
 - Sharing of food (Richard Lee's study of !Kung San).
- Religion and Rituals**
 - Animism and shamanism play roles in dispute settlement and healing.
 - Shamans hold influence but not political power.



Examples

- **Kung San (Kalahari, Africa)** –egalitarian sharing (Lee).
- **Semang (Malaysia)** –flexible band groups.
- **Iglulik Inuit (Arctic)** –resolve disputes through public ridicule or song duels.
- **Cholanaickans (Kerala)** and **Andamanese tribes** –kin-based bands in India.

Bands highlight the possibility of maintaining order without stratification or coercion. They represent the **most egalitarian form of political organization**, relying on kinship, consensus, and reciprocity.

2. Tribal Political Organization**Introduction**

Tribes are more **complex than bands** and are usually associated with **horticulture and pastoralism**. **Elman Service (1962)** described them as stateless, kinship-based groups with segmentary lineage systems.

Main Features

1. **Population and Composition**
 - Range from hundreds to several thousand.
 - Linked by **clans, moieties, or phratries**, often claiming descent from a mythical ancestor.
2. **Leadership**
 - **Headmen or elders** recognized, usually male.
 - Authority is persuasive, not coercive.
 - Based on **generosity, wisdom, conflict resolution skills**.
3. **Segmentary Lineage System**
 - **E. E. Evans-Pritchard (1940, *The Nuer*)** showed how Nuer political order was structured by segmentary lineages: clans unite against outsiders but maintain autonomy otherwise.
4. **Economic Base**
 - Horticulture (shifting cultivation) and pastoralism.
 - Food surpluses are sometimes redistributed during rituals.
5. **Social Stratification**
 - Limited stratification; **kinship ensures equality**.
 - However, elders and ritual specialists hold more respect.
6. **Conflict Resolution**
 - Headmen mediate disputes.
 - Feuds and compensation (blood wealth) are common.
 - Rituals and community councils used for peace.
7. **Religion and Rituals**
 - Ancestor worship, totemism, ritual specialists.
 - Religion legitimizes authority.
8. **Political Integration**
 - Confederacies form during warfare or external threats.
 - Once the threat passes, units dissolve back to local autonomy.

Examples

- **Nuer (Sudan)** –segmentary lineage (Evans-Pritchard).
- **Tiv (Nigeria)** –acephalous political structure (Bohannon).
- **Indian tribes:** Bhils, Gonds, and Santals –tribal confederacies.
- **Yanomami (Amazonia)** –villages united in feasts and defense.

Tribes are **stateless but structured societies**, organized through kinship and clan ties. They illustrate political integration without centralized coercion, relying instead on **lineage solidarity and ritual cohesion**.

3. Chiefdom-Level Political Organization

Chiefdoms are a **ranked form of political system**, positioned between tribes and states. **Morton Fried (1967)** defined them as ranked societies, while **Elman Service (1962)** placed them as the third evolutionary stage after bands and tribes.

Main Features

1. **Population and Territory**
 - Populations in the thousands.
 - Centralized leadership over multiple villages.
2. **Centralized Leadership**
 - Hereditary chiefs wield **political, ritual, and economic authority**.



- Chiefs often viewed as semi-divine.
- 3. **Social Stratification**
 - Ascribed inequality: chiefly lineages vs. commoners.
 - Intermarriage between ranks is restricted.
- 4. **Permanence of Office**
 - Chieftainship is institutional; succession is hereditary.
 - Chiefly office survives beyond individual rulers.
- 5. **Functions of Chiefs**
 - Control production, redistribute resources (**Polanyi: redistributive economy**).
 - Resolve disputes, mobilize labor, and plan raids.
 - Maintain ideological legitimacy through ritual.
- 6. **Expansion Strategies**
 - Control of irrigation and agricultural surplus (prehistoric Spain –**Gilman, 1991**).
 - Control of trade routes (Aegean chiefdoms).
 - Use of feasts and tribute to bind followers (Sahlins: “Big Man vs Chief” distinction).
- 7. **Religion and Ideology**
 - Chiefs often associated with gods or ancestors.
 - Rituals legitimize hereditary power.
- 8. **Military Role**
 - Chiefs organize large-scale warfare and defense.
 - Warriors serve under chiefly command.

Examples

- **Ashanti (Ghana)** –centralized under the **Asantehene**, combining tribute, military, and ritual authority (Wilks).
- **Hawaiian Chiefdoms** –hereditary chiefs, redistribution through feasts.
- **Prehistoric Spain and Aegean** –control of irrigation and trade (Gilman).
- **Tongan chiefdoms (Polynesia)** –chiefs legitimized by divine descent.

Chiefdoms represent the rise of **institutionalized hierarchy and centralized leadership**, bridging tribes and states. They show how control of **resources, rituals, and redistribution** paved the way for state formation.

4. State-Level Political Organization

The state represents the most complex and centralized form of political organization. Unlike bands, tribes, or chiefdoms, the state is characterized by **bureaucracy, stratification, and monopoly over legitimate force**. **Elman Service (1962)** placed the state at the top of his evolutionary typology, while **Morton Fried (1967)** emphasized that states institutionalize stratification.

Defining Features

- **Centralization and Bureaucracy**
 - The state has specialized governmental institutions (executive, judiciary, legislature).
 - **David S. Sandeford** defines states as socially stratified, bureaucratically governed societies with at least **four levels of settlement hierarchy** (capital, towns, villages, hamlets).
- **Population and Citizenship**
 - States define who belongs, granting rights and imposing obligations.
 - In ancient states, rights were unequal, with slaves or bonded labor excluded.
 - Modern states enshrine citizenship through constitutions.
- **Standing Army and Police**
 - Unlike part-time militias of tribes or chiefdoms, states maintain **professional forces** to enforce law and defend territory (Max Weber: monopoly of legitimate violence).
- **Information and Census Systems**
 - States keep demographic and economic records.
 - Regular censuses help with taxation, military recruitment, planning settlement, immigration control, and welfare programs.
 - Example: Mauryan Empire’s **Arthashastra** mentions systematic record-keeping.
- **Taxation and Resource Extraction**
 - States levy taxes in cash, kind, or labor.
 - In contrast, bands and tribes rely on voluntary labor for collective tasks.
 - Example: Ancient Egypt’s corvée labor for pyramid construction.
- **Law and Judiciary**
 - Formal codified laws (e.g., **Code of Hammurabi, c. 1750 BCE**) ensure uniformity and punishment.
 - Courts operate separately from kinship.



Powers of the State

- Define and regulate **citizenship**.
- Enforce **legal codes** and punish noncompliance.
- Maintain **permanent military and police**.
- Conduct **taxation and redistribution**.
- Plan and regulate **settlement, migration, and welfare**.

Symbols of State Power

- **Religion and Ideology**
 - Rulers often sanctified as divine or semi-divine.
 - Example: Egyptian Pharaohs as living gods; Indian kings as protectors of dharma.
- **Monumental Architecture**
 - Palaces, temples, and urban layouts reinforce authority.
 - Example: Mohenjo-daro's Great Bath, Egyptian pyramids, Mesopotamian ziggurats.
- **Urban Planning**
 - Capitals serve as **symbols of centralization**.
 - Proximity to central avenues reflects social rank (as seen in Teotihuacan, Mexico).

Examples

- **Ancient Mesopotamia** –city-states with kings and temple bureaucracy.
- **Mauryan Empire (India)** –centralized administration (Kautilya's *Arthashastra*).
- **Aztec and Inca states** –strong religious legitimation of rulers.
- **Modern nation-states** –defined borders, codified citizenship, bureaucracies.

States mark the culmination of political evolution with **bureaucracy, stratification, taxation, military control, and ideology** as their foundation. They incorporate bands, tribes, and chiefdoms but impose central authority over them. As **Weber (1922)** noted, the essence of the state lies in its monopoly over legitimate force, sustained through law, administration, and symbolic power.

II. Power and Authority:

Power and authority are central concepts in political anthropology and sociology, as they explain how individuals and groups influence behavior and maintain social order. While **power** refers to the capacity to enforce one's will, **authority** denotes power that is accepted as legitimate and rightful.

- **Power:**
 - It is the ability to **influence** the behavior of others with or without resistance by using a variety of tactics to push or prompt action.
 - According to _____, 'it is the **capacity** of an individual or a group to **modify others' conduct as one desires**'.
- **Authority:**
 - According to _____ – authority is the legitimate power of a person or group over other people..
 - It refers to **accepted power**, that is, power that people agree to follow.
 - People listen to authority figures because they feel that these individuals are worthy of respect.
 - Generally speaking, people perceive the objectives and demands of an authority figure as reasonable and beneficial.
 - **Legitimacy provides authority, the quality of correctness and justness**, invoking thereby, obedience and compliance as a matter of duty rather than as an outcome of coercion and force.
 - Thus, authority when associated with legitimacy, may be thought of as **"legitimate power"**.
 - **Classification of Authority:** The types of political authority were first defined by **Max Weber in his essay "Politics as a Vocation" and his other writings in 1919–1920. In this essay he emphasized that** Authority may be classified into traditional authority, charismatic authority and legal authority.
- **Traditional Authority:**
 - A tribal chief or a king is obeyed by the people under them.
 - He is accepted because it has been a **traditional authority**.
 - In traditional authority, long-standing **customs and traditions** formed the **source of political legitimacy**.
 - The sanctity of this legitimacy derived from the fact that such systems of authority had been **acknowledged and obeyed by earlier generations**.
 - Examples of traditional systems of authority are patriarchy (the rule of father over the family) or gerontocracy (the rule of the 'elders').
 - Such systems of traditional authority can still be seen in societies where **hereditary and dynastic systems of power and privilege** have survived e.g., as in Saudi Arabia, Morocco and Kuwait and its constitutional forms such as in England, Netherlands, and Spain.



- **Charismatic Authority:**
 - The second form, i.e., charismatic authority, derived legitimacy from an **individual's charismatic or appealing personality**.
 - The basis of this appeal did not rest in a person's caste, class or other ascriptive attributes.
 - It depended solely on the **personal magnetism** of the person making him/her acceptable as a leader, alluring people into obedience.
 - Examples of charismatic authority are **Mussolini, Hitler, and Napoleon**, whose leadership and popularity, unlike that of other popular leaders like John F. Kennedy depended less on the authority they derived from their political office, and more on their personal charm.
 - In simple terms, a person with extraordinary qualities is often obeyed by the people who have faith in him.
 - That denotes **charismatic authority**.
- **Legal authority:**
 - Weber's third kind of legitimacy, legal-rational, links authority to a precise and legally defined set of rules.
 - **Legal-rational form of authority, for Weber, is the typical form of authority found in most modern states.**
 - In such authority systems, unlike charismatic and traditional forms, political power is derived from, dependent upon, and limited by formal, legal, constitutional rules.
 - It is these rules, which determine the nature and scope of the office holder's power.
 - In simple terms, Legal authority is **formal** and **law defines its privileges**.
 - Hence the **power is not in the person but in the positions s/he holds**.
 - When s/he **loses that position the power is also lost**.

Thus, while **power** may rely on coercion or force, **authority** rests on legitimacy and acceptance. Max Weber's typology of **traditional, charismatic, and legal-rational authority** provides a framework to understand how leadership and governance function across societies, from tribal chiefdoms to modern states. Together, these concepts reveal that political control is not only about dominance but also about cultural recognition of rightful rule.

III. Social Control Mechanisms:

- 'Social Control refers to the **patterns of pressure** which a society exerts to **maintain order and establish rules**'
- Social control is the **process which helps to maintain proper social order**.
- Social control refers to **social and political mechanisms that regulate individual and group behavior**.
- It is an important function of political organization.

Types of Social Control Mechanisms:

According to _____, Social control mechanisms can be of two types – Formal and Informal

- **Formal and Informal Control:**
 - **Formal Control:**
 - Formal means of social control includes **external sanctions enforced by the government** to prevent the establishment of chaos in society.
 - Eg: Laws made by government, Police, courts
 - **Informal Control:**
 - **Social norms and values** exist in societies that play an **important role in maintaining social order**.
 - These social norms and values are **transmitted through generations** through the process of **socialization**.
 - **Includes internalized norms and values of the society**.
 - Eg: In pre-literate **societies customary laws, moral values and social sanctions** function as informal means of social control.

Social Sanction:

- Sanctions are mechanisms of **social control** that guide behavior by rewarding conformity and discouraging deviance. They reflect the values and norms of society.
- As _____ noted, even the anticipation of sanctions, whether approval or punishment, can be enough to regulate individual behavior.

Types of Sanctions:

- **Positive and Negative Sanctions:**
 - **Positive Sanction:** Rewards that encourage conformity, such as praise, honor, titles, promotions, or awards.
 - **Negative Sanction:** Punishments that discourage deviance, such as fines, imprisonment, beating, or social disapproval
- **Formal and Informal Sanction:**
 - **Formal sanction:**



- A formal sanction is referred to as a clearly defined reward or punishment with specific people authorized to deliver it.
- It can also **refer to social norms enforced through the laws of the criminal justice system.**
- It **encourages people to comply with legislation.**
- Just for your knowledge:
 - **Negative formal sanctions** in our society include low grades, suspension from school, termination from a job, fines, and imprisonment.
 - **Positive formal sanctions** in our society: Graduation certificates, pay raises, promotions, awards, and medals are examples of positive formal sanctions.
- **Informal Sanction:**
 - **Social values** present in individuals are the products of informal social control, **exercised implicitly by a society through particular customs, norms and mores.**
 - Individuals **internalize the values of their society through socialization and enculturation.**
 - **Eg:** shame, ridicule, sarcasm, criticism, and disapproval
 - Just for your knowledge:
 - **Positive informal sanctions** in our society include standing ovations, compliments, smiles, pats on the back, and gifts.
 - **Negative informal sanctions** in our society include frowns, gossip, rebukes, insults, ridicule, and ostracism, exclusion from a particular group.
 - Informal sanctions are particularly effective among members of simple societies, to whom group acceptance is important.

Social sanctions, whether **formal or informal, positive or negative**, are powerful tools for maintaining social order. They operate not only through legal and institutional mechanisms but also through everyday interactions, ensuring that individuals internalize social values and regulate their own behavior.

Customary Law:

Customary law refers to the body of unwritten rules and practices that regulate social behavior in simple and pre-literate societies. Unlike codified state laws, it evolves organically from **customs, kinship relations, religion, and public opinion**. As _____ note, primitive law consists of principles that permit the use of force to maintain political and social order within a territory. Thus, customary law reflects the cultural values of a community and serves as a key mechanism of social control.

- **Nature of Customary law:**
 - It is **based on kinship** as most of the members of simple societies are **related by blood** and generally kinship rules are followed as law.
 - It is **backed by positive and negative sanctions.**
 - It depends on **customs**, as law and customs are interdependent.
 - Maintaining social justice is a **collective responsibility**. Everybody is a policeman in simple societies.
 - Crime is determined on the basis of **oath and ordeal**.
- **Sources of Customary Law:**
 1. Customs
 2. Social organization / Social Panchayat
 3. Public opinion
 4. Religion
 5. Nature
 6. Oral traditions

1. Customs:

- Customs are the **body of practices and conventions** that regulate social life. Just as in complex societies, **pre-literate communities** also rely on **unwritten norms** that function like laws, guiding both **individual conduct** and **collective behavior**.
- *Example:* Among the **!Kung** are of the **Kalahari Desert region of Southern Africa**, customs dictate strict rules of food sharing after a successful hunt. A hunter cannot keep all the meat for himself, because hoarding would disrupt group survival in the harsh desert environments. If someone fails to share, others openly ridicule him and he may lose his reputation, which acts as an informal but powerful law.

2. Social organization / Social Panchayat:

- Every simple society has some form of **social organization**, often based on **kinship**.
- **Leaders or chiefs** hold authority but must act in the **interest of the group**. In many cases, the **chief's word is treated as law**.
- Punishments are **restorative** rather than punitive – for example, requiring the offender to **host a feast** for the entire community.



- Failure to comply may result in **ostracism by one's kin group**.
- **Example:** Among the **Igbo of Nigeria**, there is no centralized state. Instead, village assemblies and councils of elders handle disputes and enforce decisions. If a person commits an offense, elders may order compensation or a public apology. In some cases, the guilty party must host a communal feast, reinforcing both punishment and social solidarity.

3. Public opinion:

- **Public opinion** is a **powerful force** in small-scale societies.
- **Approval or disapproval** from the community determines social standing.
- Individuals who break norms face **ridicule, gossip, or exclusion**, making collective judgment an effective **form of sanction**.
- **Example:** Among the **Trobriand Islanders** studied by Malinowski, gossip, mockery, and ridicule are used to control behavior. If someone breaks norms related to exchange in the Kula trade or marriage alliances, others spread gossip that damages the person's prestige, which in turn pressures them to conform.

4. Religion:

- **Religion** is an **integral part of life** in simple societies, offering a **code of conduct** that is as binding as secular law.
- Violations of religious rules are believed to invite **supernatural punishment** not only upon the offender but also on the **community as a whole**.
- This fear ensures **compliance with religious norms**.
- **Example:** Among the **Ashanti of Ghana**, insulting a chief or violating taboos linked to ancestral spirits is considered a grave crime. Such acts are punished severely, sometimes by physical mutilation or ostracism. Here, religion and law merge, since breaking religious rules is seen as endangering the entire community by invoking ancestral wrath.

5. Nature:

- Customary laws are often shaped by the **natural environment** and **resource use**.
- For example, in **hunting and gathering societies**, rules ensure **sustainable exploitation** of resources.
 - Among the **Baiga tribes**, hunting customs prohibit killing **pregnant animals or very young ones**, maintaining the **long-term balance of wildlife**.

6. Oral traditions:

- Customary law is preserved and transmitted through **oral traditions** rather than written codes.
- **Stories, songs, proverbs, and ceremonies** serve as vehicles for passing rules across generations.
- In many **Indigenous communities**, oral traditions ensure that law is **remembered, internalized, and tied to cultural identity**.

Customary law demonstrates that even in the absence of codified statutes, societies maintain order through **collective responsibility, kinship-based rules, sanctions, and oral traditions**. It highlights the interdependence of law, custom, and religion in pre-literate societies, showing how justice is embedded in everyday life. By studying customary law, anthropology shows that law is not only a legal framework but also a **social institution rooted in culture and tradition**.

Primitive Law vs Modern Law:

1. Customary Law vs Written Law

- *Primitive societies:* Laws passed down through customs and traditions, unwritten rules, and community practices.
- *Modern societies:* Laws are **written and codified**, providing a clear, formal guide for citizens.

2. Single Council vs Specialized Councils

- *Primitive law:* A single council handled adjudication and enforcement.
- *Modern law:* Hierarchical and specialized courts (**district, high, civil, criminal**) deal with specific cases.

3. Trial by Oath and Ordeal vs Trial by Evidence

- *Primitive law:* Trials relied on rituals such as oaths and ordeals.
- *Modern law:* Emphasizes **evidence-based trials**, physical examination, cross-questioning, and rules of evidence.

4. Collective Responsibility vs Specialized Officers

- *Primitive law:* Law enforcement was the responsibility of the whole community.
- *Modern law:* **Specialized officers (police)** are responsible for implementation.

5. Public Opinion vs Constitution and Law

- *Primitive law:* Justice influenced by **public opinion** and council decisions.
- *Modern law:* Justice based on **constitution, statutes, and legal principles**.

6. Punishment Types

- *Primitive law:* Fines, compensation, communal feasts, or physical penalties.
- *Modern law:* Fines, compensation, **imprisonment, capital punishment, exile**, etc.



7. Family Punishment vs Individual Punishment

- *Primitive law*: The entire family could be punished for one member's offense.
- *Modern law*: **Individual responsibility** – only the culprit is punished.

Summary Table:

Primitive law	Modern law
Customary law	Written law
Single council for adjudication	Different councils like district court, high court, civil court and criminal court.
Trial in the form of oath and ordeal	Trial using physical examination and cross questioning of witness
All members are responsible for implementation of law	Special officers like police are responsible for implementation of law.
Justice is based on public opinion and decision of council	Based on constitution and law
Punishment in the form of fine, compensation, communal feast, punishment etc.	Punishment in the form of fine, compensation, imprisonment, capital out casting, exile..
In primitive law it is not the individual but the whole family is punished	Only the culprit is punished

Dispute settlement in the pre-literate societies:

Disputes occur in every society, but the methods of resolving them vary according to cultural complexity and political organization. In **pre-literate societies**, where written laws and formal courts are absent, mechanisms such as **oaths, ordeals, mediation, and community action** serve to maintain order. Scholars like _____ highlighted that in small, closely knit communities, disputes are settled through customs, supernatural beliefs, and collective responsibility rather than codified laws. These processes reflect both the cultural values and the social cohesion of such societies.

- In **simplest societies**, **judges** are the people themselves.
- A judge may be an **elderly kinsman**, where council of elders is called into being and they constitute the judges.
- The **authorized persons** get together to **hear a case and pass the judgment**. In most of the cases the accused denies the particular charge against him.
- Until and unless his innocence is proved, he does not get mercy.
- Therefore judgment essentially comprises **few parts**.
 - **Evidence**: It can be in the form of
 - **Oath**:
 - It is a promise in the name of God not to tell a lie.
 - It is said that, if the facts furnished by a person are proved false, the person will be punished by God.
 - This is a technique of compelling one to confess his own guilt voluntarily.
 - Usually a sinner does not conceal his guilt for the fear of supernatural wrath.
 - **Eg: Among the _____, an accused is brought before Jhanda Gossaiya that they revere and fear, and is asked to touch a knife placed at the sacred centre and say, while touching the knife, 'I will die if I lie.'**
 - **Ordeal**:
 - An **ordeal** is a means used to **determine guilt or innocence by submitting the accused to dangerous or painful tests** believed to be under supernatural control.
 - **Eg: Oraons– two accused members place hot burning charcoal in their palm – and the one who drops it first is considered as the culprit. Why? Because the innocent will be given powers by the supernatural forces to endure unlike for the sinner.**
 - **Another type of Maler tribe– Pochai beer** (Remember the Pochai beer example from the class?)
 - A type of check against illicit sex relations is drinking of ritualistic pochai (rice beer). The religious head creates a ritualistic atmosphere so that the guilty person does not dare



drink pochai. It is supposed that the sinner would definitely die after drinking the pochai. Innocent will drink and is believed to not die.

- Why? The fear is not whether it is poisonous or not, but whether there is truth in the person or not. It may not be poisonous at all, but for a sinner it is believed to be poisonous.
- **Ordeal by boiling oil** has been practiced among **Tanala of Madagascar**. The accused parties are ordered to retrieve an item from a container of boiling oil, with those who refuse the task being found guilty.
- In Ancient India, the trial by fire was known as **agnipariksha**, in which Agni, the Fire God, would be invoked by a priest using mantras. After the invocation, a pyre is built and lit, and the accused would be asked to sit on it. According to Hindu mythology, the **Fire God would protect the accused** if they were innocent, if not, they would be burned to ashes. Remember how **Sita proves her purity by fire ordeal in The Ramayana?**
- [Sita, the wife of Lord Rama, had to undergo a trial by fire to prove her innocence and purity. She emerged unscathed, proving her innocence to all].
- **Why do some societies use oaths and ordeals?**
 - _____ suggested that their use tends to be found in **fairly complex societies** in which **political officials lack sufficient power** to make and enforce **judicial decisions**. So the officials may use oaths and ordeals to **let the gods determine guilt or innocence**.
 - When political officials **gain more power**, oaths and ordeals seem to **decline or disappear**.
 - In contrast, **smaller and less complex societies** probably have no need for elaborate mechanisms like oath and ordeal to ascertain guilt since in such societies, **everyone is aware of what crimes** have been committed and **who the guilty parties probably are**.
- **Trial:**
 - In general, one finds some **rudimentary form of trial** before the award of punishment.
 - Both the petitioner and the defendant present their cases before the chief and the council of elders who carefully hear them and sometimes cross question them.
 - In certain societies, physical injuries are inflicted as punishment for certain crimes.
 - **Eg:**
 - **American tribes:** An **unfaithful wife** is punished with **death by drowning** in water.
 - **Ugandan tribes:** There is a provision of **jail**, but if the crime is very serious, the **criminal is tied to a pole until death**.
 - **Oraons (India):** In clans where **exogamy** is strictly followed, a member must **choose a mate from another clan**. Violation of this rule leads to **trial and punishment** before the village council.
- **Punishment:**
 - **Retribution:**
 - It is the act of **taking revenge**
 - Most of the tribal people believe that crime is a violation of the divine system or rules.
 - Hence, it is believed that **the criminal is evil who should be given suitable punishment, so that s/he may become free from evil**.
 - **Collective responsibilities:**
 - According to this principle punishment is **not necessarily awarded to an individual** who has committed the crime **but his family, clan and local group may also be punished**.
 - So, the entire kin group is considered guilty, and any of them can be punished.
- **Wergild (Compensation):**
 - Like the civilized societies most of **the simple societies have provision for compensation for the loss due to crime**.
 - The **fine may be charged in cash or in kind or in both**, depending upon the **seriousness of the crime** and the **capacity of the culprit to pay it**.
 - **Eg: Kuwait blood money:**
 - Blood money, also known as **diyya or diya**, is a **payment made to the victim or the victim's family** in certain legal systems as **compensation for injury or loss**, especially in cases involving crimes such as murder or injury. It is often **paid by the perpetrator or their family** as a way to **compensate for the harm** caused and to avoid further retribution or punishment.



Means of Settlement of Disputes:

Disputes arise in all societies, but the methods of resolution vary according to cultural context and social complexity. Broadly, they can be categorized into **peaceful** and **violent** means.

Peaceful and Violent Means

When regular and effective mechanisms of dispute settlement are absent, people may resort to violence. Some societies even view certain forms of interpersonal violence as acceptable under specific circumstances, though in modern contexts these would be considered crimes. When conflict escalates between political entities such as communities, districts, or nations, it is termed **warfare**, which itself ranges in scale from **feuding** and **raiding** to **large-scale confrontations** (Ember).

Perspectives on Human Nature

Debates over the roots of conflict often center on differing views of human nature.

- _____ argued that humans are **innately violent**, requiring strong societal structures to control destructive tendencies.
 - _____, in contrast, believed that humans in their natural state were **peaceful and cooperative**, and that violence arose mainly due to external pressures such as inequality or social disruption.
 - **Peaceful Means of Settlement**
 - Simple societies have their own mechanisms through which most disputes are settled peacefully: These include
 - **Avoidance,**
 - **community action,**
 - **negotiation and mediation,**
 - **apology,**
 - **oath, ordeal and**
 - **adjudication.**
- **Avoidance:**
 - Violence is avoided when disputing parties separate until tensions cool down.
 - **Example:** Foragers often move to other bands or shift their dwellings to opposite ends of the camp.
 - **Community action:**
 - Collective action by the group substitutes for authoritarian leadership.
 - **Example:** Among the **Inuit of Alaska**, community pressure and ridicule are used to maintain peace.
 - **Negotiation and mediation:**
 - Disputants may settle issues themselves (negotiation) or with the help of a third party (mediation).
 - **Example:** Among the **Nuer of South Sudan** (Evans-Pritchard), lineage elders mediate disputes.
 - **Apology:**
 - Ritualized apologies restore harmony.
 - Ceremonial apologies are **formal, ritualized expressions of remorse or regret** that are often used in simple societies as a way of resolving conflicts or repairing relationships.
 - The guilty party (parties) asks for forgiveness.
 - **Example:** In **Fiji**, the ritual of *i soro* ("surrender") involves offering apology to repair relationships.
 - **Oath and Ordeal:**
 - An **Oath** is the act of calling upon a deity to bear witness to the truth of what one says.
 - An **ordeal** is a means used to determine guilt or innocence by submitting the accused to dangerous or painful tests believed to be under supernatural control.
 - **Eg:** Among the **Maler**, an accused swears on sacred objects; among the **Oraon**, an ordeal with burning charcoal is used.
 - **Adjudication:**
 - Adjudication is when **a third party acts as judge** and **takes a decision that the disputing parties have to accept.**
 - Judgment may be regarded by one person, a panel of judges, a young person, or a political agent.
 - **Eg: Our own society relies heavily on codified law and courts** to resolve disputes peacefully.
 - **Why do some societies have codified systems and others do not?**
 - One explanation by **E·Adamson Hoebel, A.R.Radcliffe-Brown** is that- in **small, closely knit communities**, there is **little need for formal legal guidelines** because competing interests are minimal (therefore, they need little codified law).



- For Eg: Amongst **Ashantis**:
 - Criminal & religious law were merged (Eg: Crimes, especially homicide, cursing of a chief were regarded as sins against ancestral spirits).
 - Appeals against a verdict could be **made directly to a chief**.
 - Ashanti punishments could be **severe**. (Eg: **physical mutilation**– such as slicing off the nose or an ear, even **castration** in sexual offenses–was often employed)
 - **Drunkenness** constituted a valid defense for all crimes except murder & cursing a chief & plea of insanity if proved, was upheld for all offenses.
 - **Violent means of settlement:**
 - People are likely to resort to violence when regular, effective alternative means of resolving a conflict are not available or satisfactory.
 - Some societies consider violence between individuals to be appropriate under circumstances. This include:
 - **Individual violence**
 - **Feuding**
 - **Raid**
 - **Large scale confrontations or warfare**
 - **Individual violence:**
 - Violent behavior itself is often used to try to control behavior.
 - In political anthropology, individual violence refers to the **use of physical force** by an individual or group to **settle a dispute or conflict**. This can include actions such as **fighting, assault, and murder**.
 - In some societies, individual violence may be seen as an **acceptable** or even preferred method of resolving conflicts, particularly among men.
 - However, in many societies, individual violence is **condemned** and is often **regulated or punished by law**.
 - Alternative methods of resolving conflicts, such as **mediation or negotiation**, are often encouraged as a more **peaceful and effective way to resolve disputes**.
 - In some societies a **person trespasses a property which is considered a justification of a crime**.
 - **Example:** Have you seen Trespassers being shot outside private estates in the US?
 - In some societies, trespass or insults justify violent retaliation.
- **Feuding:**
 - **Feuding is a state of recurring hostility** between **families or groups of kin**.
 - It is usually **motivated by a desire to avenge an offense** against a member of their group.
 - **Example: Nunamiut Inuit feud** studied by **Nicholas Gubser** lasted decades after a husband killed his wife's lover.
- **Raiding:**
 - Raiding is a short term use of force that is **planned and organized to realize a limited objective**.
 - This objective is **usually the acquisition of goods, animals or other forms of wealth** belonging to other, often neighboring communities.
 - **Raiding** may also be organized for the purpose of capturing persons either to **marry** or to keep as concubines or as **slaves**.
 - **Slavery** has been practiced in about **33 percent** of the world's known societies, and war has been one way of obtaining slaves either to keep or to trade for other goods.
 - **Example: North American Tribes– Horse raiding**
- **Large scale confrontations or warfare:**
 - Large scale confrontation involves a large number of persons and planning by both sides of strategies of **attack and defense**.



- Large scale warfare is usually practiced among societies with intensive agriculture or industrialisation.
- Only these societies possess a technology sufficiently advanced to support **specialized armies, military leaders, strategies**, and so on..
- **Example:** _____
- **Ritual small-scale warfare between rival villages** was an integral part to traditional Dani culture, with much time spent preparing weapons and treating resulting injuries. Typically the **emphasis in battle is to insult the enemy** and wound or kill token victims, as opposed to capturing territory or property or vanquishing the enemy village. Such fighting is no longer done.

Dispute settlement in pre-literate societies demonstrates that law and justice are not limited to formal courts or written codes but are embedded in **kinship, religion, and community norms**. Peaceful mechanisms such as **avoidance, apology, negotiation, and adjudication** often prevail, though violent means like **feuds, raids, or warfare** may emerge when peaceful options fail. The study of these practices, from **oaths among the Maler** to **ordeals among the Oraons**, shows how social order is maintained without centralized states. It also underscores the idea that law is a **cultural institution shaped by belief, values, and social structure**, not merely a legal code.

Paper 1- Chapter 5

5. Religion :

Syllabus covered:

- I. Anthropological approaches to the study of religion (evolutionary, psychological and functional); Monotheism and polytheism;
- II. Sacred and profane;
- III. Myths and rituals;
- IV. Forms of religion in tribal and peasant Societies (animism, animatism, fetishism, naturism and totemism);
- V. Religion, magic and science distinguished;
- VI. Magico-religious functionaries (priest, shaman, medicine man, sorcerer and witch).

RELIGION:

- The word **religion** has been derived from the root word **religio**, which means '**to bind together**' and religion actually does it. It has had the most profound influence over human thought since the ancient past.
- **Anthropology of religion is the study of religion in relation to other social institutions.**
- Anthropology looks at religion from a **historical and evolutionary perspective**, going into its origin and development and also the **functional perspective**, exploring its contemporary practices and manifestations.

Definition:

- There is no single definition of religion that could have universal application.
- British anthropologist **E B Tylor** has given the minimal definition of religion as "**a belief in spiritual beings**" (**Primitive Culture 1871**)
- _____'s definition: "**A religion is a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things**".
- _____ defines religion as "**the beliefs and practices concerned with supernatural beings, powers and forces**".
- However, there is no single definition of religion that could have universal application.

Functions of Religion:

- **Psychological function:**
 - It also provides psychological function by **reducing fears and anxieties** in a crisis.
 - Religion offers emotional comfort, particularly when people face a crisis.
- **Integrative function:**
 - One of the major functions of religion is **social integration**.
 - It binds together the members of a society when they believe in the same thing and participate in the same religious rituals.
- **Function of Social Control:**
 - Every religion stresses a **moral code and conduct** to all of its members through the concepts of right, wrong, good and evil.
 - Religion controls social life.
 - The right actions of individuals result in the **approval of supernatural power and thereby approval from society**.



- **Explanatory function:**
 - Religion has an explanatory function.
 - Religion provides an **explanation to individual and group life**.
 - People all over the world wonder how this universe originated, why people die and suffer from diseases, and so on.
- **Validation function:**
 - Religion has validating functions.
 - Religious beliefs and practices are important in all cultures.
 - It validates peoples' customs, beliefs and values.

I. Anthropological approaches to the study of religion (evolutionary, psychological and functional):

Religion is an important part of human life. Anthropologists studied it in different ways – some explained how it evolved, some looked at the human mind behind it, and some saw how it helps society.

- **Evolutionary Approach:**
 - This approach was influenced by **E.B. Tylor's concept of 'unilineal evolution'**, from simple to complex.
 - **Tylor** in his "**Primitive culture**" traced the evolution of religion from **Animism to Polytheism to Monotheism**.
 - **R.R. Marett** disagreed that the earliest form would be belief in soul (he felt that belief in soul is a sophisticated idea and not likely for earliest men). He traced his evolution to be from **Animatism to Polytheism to Monotheism**.
 - Among the most influential elements of *The Golden Bough* is **Frazer's theory of cultural evolution** and the place Frazer assigns religion and magic in that theory.
 - Frazer's theory of cultural evolution sought to broadly describe three stages through which cultures were thought to pass over time.
 - Frazer believed that, over time, culture passed through three stages, moving from magic, to religion, to science.
 - **Hence, in his "The Golden Bough", Frazer advocated evolution as Magic to Religion to Science**
 - Criticism:
 - Will be the same as all the criticisms from Classical Evolutionism. Refer Chapter 6(a) of our syllabus.
 - Underlying 'Psychic unity of mankind'
 - Ethnocentric viewing of the world
- **Psychological Approach:**
 - This approach was based on the _____ premise – that **religious practices** can be usefully interpreted as **expressions of unconscious psychological forces**.
 - According to him, a **deep subconscious psychological conflict within social groups is responsible for the development of religion**.
 - He explains that the psychological conflict between the father and son, the hatred of the son towards the father, his desire for killing him and the guilt feeling are the reasons for the creation of the totem based on the **Oedipus myth**.
 - **The worship or respect shown to the totemic animal is the reflection of subconscious conflict between the son and father and the latter's kinsmen.**
 - The psychological defense mechanisms involve projections to **avoid conflict and reduce anxiety**.
 - Eg: Creation of Totem based on Oedipus myth
 - Freud's interest in Greek mythology and religion greatly influenced his psychological theories.
 - **Oedipus Complex and Origin of Religion (totemism):**
 - In 1913, **Freud** published the book, _____.
 - This book was an attempt to reconstruct the birth and the process of development of religion as a social institution.
 - The Oedipus complex is when a boy is jealous of his father.
 - The boy strives to possess his mother and ultimately replace his father as a means of no longer having to fight for her undivided attention and affection.
 - Along with seeking his mother's love, boys also experience castration anxiety which is the fear of losing his genitalia.
 - Boys fear that their fathers will retaliate and castrate them as a result of desiring one's mother.
 - **Totemism originates from the memory of this event in prehistory where the male group members eat the father figure due to a desire for the females (especially the mother).**
 - The guilt they feel for their actions and for the loss of a father figure leads them to prohibit incest in a new way.
 - **Totemism is a means of preventing incest and as a ritual reminder of the murder of the father.**



- This shows that sexual desire, since there are **many social prohibitions** on sexual relations, is **channeled through certain ritual actions** and **all societies adapt these rituals so that sexuality develops in approved ways.**
- **Criticism: Richard Webster** describes **psychoanalysis** as "perhaps the most complex and successful" **pseudoscience** in history.
 - [Just for context (not to be written): The Oedipus myth is a tragic tale from Greek mythology that centers around Oedipus, the king of Thebes. The story is primarily told through various plays, with Sophocles' "Oedipus Rex" being one of the most famous.
 - Here is a condensed version of the Oedipus myth:
 - King Laius of Thebes receives a prophecy that his son will kill him and marry his wife, Queen Jocasta. To prevent this, Laius orders a servant to kill the infant Oedipus. However, the servant cannot bring himself to commit the act and instead leaves the baby on a mountainside to die.
 - Oedipus is found and adopted by King Polybus and Queen Merope of Corinth. As he grows older, Oedipus hears a prophecy that he will kill his father and marry his mother. Disturbed by this, he decides to leave Corinth and avoid his supposed fate.
 - On his journey, Oedipus encounters King Laius at a crossroads and, unknowingly, kills him in a fit of rage during an altercation. Continuing his journey, he arrives in Thebes, which is suffering from the curse of the Sphinx. Oedipus solves the Sphinx's riddle, freeing the city from the curse, and is rewarded by being made king. As a reward, he is given the widowed Queen Jocasta as his wife, fulfilling the prophecy unbeknownst to them.
 - Years later, as Thebes faces a new crisis, Oedipus seeks the truth behind the city's troubles. Through a series of revelations, he discovers the horrifying reality of his actions – that he killed his father and married his mother. Jocasta, upon realizing the truth, takes her own life, and Oedipus, unable to bear the weight of his actions, blinds himself.
 - The Oedipus myth explores themes of fate, free will, and the tragic consequences of trying to escape one's destiny. It remains a classic and powerful narrative in Western literature and drama.
 - Freud and Oedipus complex:
The Oedipus myth, while originating in Greek mythology, has intriguing connections to Freudian psychology, particularly Freud's concept of the Oedipus complex. Freud drew inspiration from the tragic narrative to develop his theory, positing that individuals undergo a psychological process wherein they experience unconscious desires for their opposite-sex parent and harbor rivalry with the same-sex parent. The Oedipus myth serves as a literary exploration of these complex dynamics, delving into the consequences of hidden desires and the interplay between fate and individual choices. Additionally, Freud's use of the term "Totem and Taboo" in his work further connects to the Oedipus myth, as he explored primal aspects of human psychology and societal structures through the lens of totemism. The Oedipus narrative, with its themes of destiny, familial relationships, and psychological complexities, continues to captivate scholars and psychologists alike, offering rich material for the exploration of human behavior and the intersection of mythology with psychological theory.]
- **Psychological Approach by Carl Jung:**
 - **Swiss psychoanalyst Carl Jung** approached the study of religion with empathy. He was particularly interested in the symbolic aspects of religion. Jung introduced the idea of the '**collective unconscious**,' a shared part of our minds that contains universal images known as '**archetypes**.' These archetypes are basic images that show up across different cultures.
 - According to **Jung**, these archetypes play a big role in shaping what he called 'religious experiences' and even sparking creativity in art. He believed that when these universal images from our unconscious mind come to the surface of our awareness, they form the foundation of religious experiences and often inspire artistic expression.
 - **Example:**
 - Think of the collective unconscious as a shared mental space where everyone has certain common ideas. Archetypes could be like fundamental symbols that appear in myths and religions worldwide, such as the idea of a hero, a wise old person, or a journey of transformation. When people from different cultures share similar stories or symbols, Jung would say it's because they tap into these universal archetypes.
 - **Criticism:**
 - Some critics, like Richard Webster, have called psychoanalysis, the method Jung used, a "pseudoscience," which means it's seen as not entirely scientific. This criticism suggests that while Jung's ideas are influential, they might lack the empirical rigor associated with more established scientific disciplines.



In summary, the Psychological Approach, as championed by Jung, emphasizes the role of shared, universal symbols in shaping religious experiences and artistic expression. However, it's not without its skeptics, with some considering aspects of this approach less scientifically rigorous.

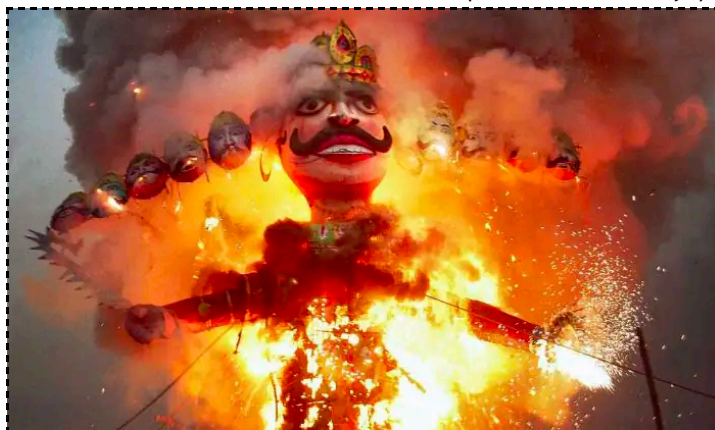
- **Functional Approach:**

- This approach was based on the functionality of religion to serve the needs of individuals (**Malinowski**) or to maintain social structure and promote social stability/solidarity. (**Radcliffe-Brown**)
- In other words, it serves to **reduce anxiety & create social bonding**.
- Eg: **Malinowski Functional perspective:** His study on **Trobriand Islanders** illustrates the rituals performed before venturing out into the high seas for fishing (reduces stress and anxiety).
 - Imagine us writing exams. Despite good preparation levels, we still pray to god to reduce stress and anxiety, right?
- Eg: **Radcliffe-Brown's Structural Functionalist perspective** – the 'function' of a religion was just its role in **sustaining the overall social structure**, insofar as there was a stable social structure. So religion helps in **maintaining social structure**, promoting social solidarity, and integrating the people together.
 - Imagine South Indian Hindu societies – they have relatives come together during **Amavasya / Purnima**. Hindus traditionally memorialize the dead with a yearly death ritual known as the **shraddha ceremony**. All of these act to promote social solidarity and maintain social structure.
- Eg: In India, **M.N. Srinivas' (1952)** study of **society and religion among the Coorgs** is an outstanding contribution to the **study of religion from a functionalist perspective**. He very innovatively integrates social structure with religion which he finds operating at different levels –local, regional, peninsular and all India. He demonstrates that **various rituals organized at family, patrilineal joint family (okka), village and nad level bring in solidarity and unity among different social segments**.

In conclusion, the evolutionary, psychological and functional approaches highlight different dimensions of religion– its growth over time, its roots in the human mind, and its role in social life. Together they show that religion is not just belief in the supernatural, but also a way for humans to cope with fears, express emotions, and strengthen community bonds.

II. Concept of Sacred and Profane:

- _____ in his famous book _____ used two important concepts, viz, '**sacred**' and '**profane**', which are still used and debated all over the world in the study of 'primitive' religion.
- Durkheim considered these two concepts as central to the understanding of religion.
- **Sacred:**
 - The word 'sacred' has been derived from the **French word 'sacre'** which means **pure with religious sanctity**.
 - Supernatural beings and forces are considered to be **holy** and thus they are treated as **sacred**.
 - Durkheim was of the opinion that in religion, there is only **sacred belief**; belief which refers to God and the deities who are actually symbolic of society itself.
 - He was also of the opinion that the **sacred** encompasses **not only the good but also of the evil** and impure.
 - For Rama, there's Ravana
 - For Pandavas, there's Kauravas
 - For Devas, there's Asuras
 - For truth, there's evil (Remember, truth triumphs over evil – Vijayadashmi)

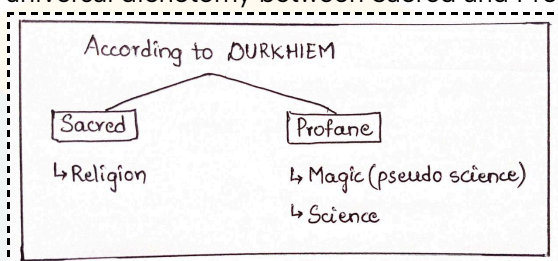


How to tell if something is sacred or not?

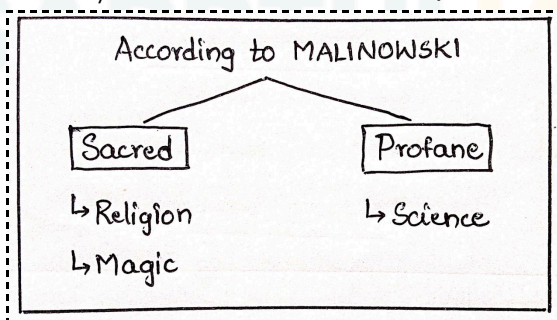
Sacredness can be seen in terms of symbolism. For instance, All religions rely on the use of symbols to create the Sacred.



- Rituals, such as prayer and ablution, are a form of symbolic practice that highlight faith.
- Objects can also take on Sacred meaning, such as the Cross or the Star of David, and certain types of dress or grooming practices.
- Totems confer in-group membership to those who wear or use these symbols and provide a way for people to demonstrate their faith and recognize that faith in others.
- **Profane:**
 - The word 'profane' means **mundane** and hence **related to worldly affairs**.
 - Everything that is **not sacred is profane**.
 - Thus, the profane beliefs and practices are not sacred and hence do not form part of religion.
 - **Example:**
 - Let us take an example: Why are believers not allowed to wear their shoes or slippers inside a temple?
 - Wearing footwear for walking is a routine, or profane act.
 - The temple is considered a holy place; it is sacred. The floor of the temple must therefore be protected from the polluting dirt of our footwear. Hence, the sacred and profane are kept apart.
- **Anthropologists' views on Sacred-Profane:**
 - **Durkheim:** He defines : "A **religion** is a unified system of **beliefs and practices** relative to **sacred things**, that is to say, beliefs and practices which unite into one single moral community called a Church, all those who adhere to them."
 - In other words, he's suggesting that the **religions** represent the **sacred** while the **magic** (or the pseudo-science) and **science** is part of the **profane**.
 - He also argued that there's a universal dichotomy between Sacred and Profane elements of society.



- **Malinowski:** suggested that religion and magic both represent the sacred while science is part of the profane.
- **Why?** This is because he believed that both Religion and Magic both perform similar functions in society – (reducing stress and anxiety of the individual members).

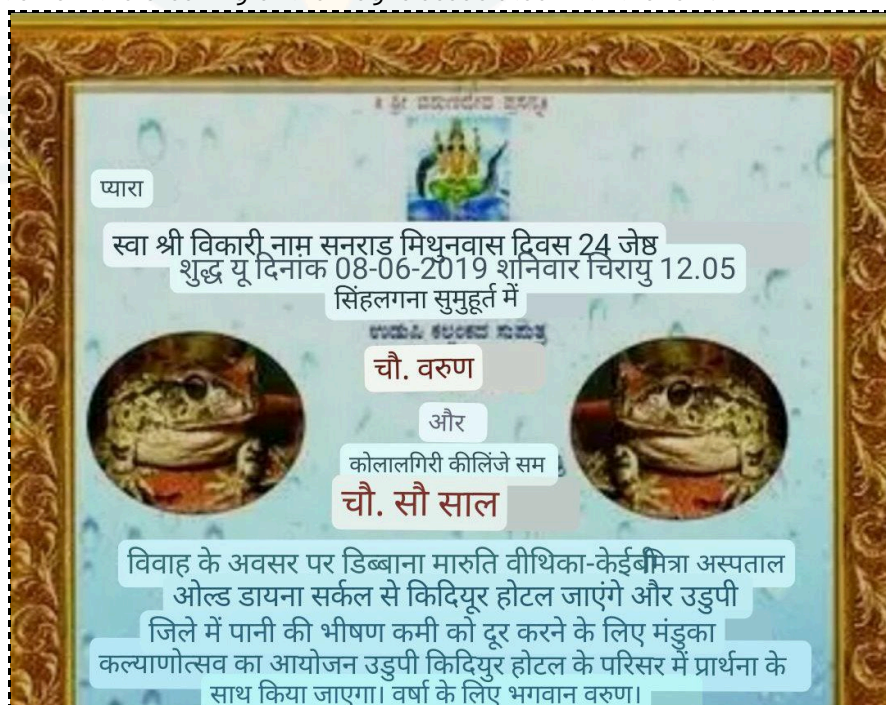


- **Criticism of Sacred-Profane Dichotomy:**
 - _____, however, maintained that sacred-profane dichotomy is not universal.
 - He bases this based on his study amongst the _____ wherein such clearcut distinctions between the sacred and profane don't exist and both of these are inextricably interwoven in their everyday life.
 - In simple terms, **sacred and profane are not always antithetical**.

III. Myth and rituals:

- **Myth** and **ritual** are two core elements of **religion**, often found together across cultures. **Anthropologists** have long debated their **relationship**. Some believe that **myths give rise to rituals**, others argue that **rituals give rise to myths**, and some see them as existing **independently** while still serving important **social** and **psychological** functions.
- What are the anthropological perspectives or studies on Myths and Rituals?
 - Among the many theories of myth and many theories of ritual, the myth and ritual theory is distinctive in connecting myths to rituals.
 - The myth and ritual, or myth-ritualist theory maintains that **myths and rituals operate together**. –

- **Classical Evolutionists perspectives:** Classical Evolutionists saw myth and ritual as **survivals** of earlier stages of human development, which they believed to be evidence of the **evolution of human culture**. They basically tried to understand the **sequence** as to which came first. (We will be dealing with this in detail in chapter 6). The different views put forth by some of the Classical Evolutionists are as follows:
 - **Ritual arose from Myths: EB Tylor**
 - Provides a analogy between **Science :: Technology : Myth :: Ritual**
 - Just as technology is an application of science, so ritual is an application of myth.
 - In other words, **just like science gives rise to technology, myths give rise to rituals.**
 - For instance, many religious rituals, notably **Passover among Jews, Christmas and Easter among Christians, and the Hajj among Muslims, commemorate events in religious literature (myths).**
 - For eg: Passover, also called Pesach, is a major Jewish holiday that celebrates the Biblical story of the Israelites escape from slavery in Egypt, which occurs on the 15th day of the Hebrew month of Nisan, the first month of Aviv, or spring.
 - **Christmas and Easter** are both Christian holidays that commemorate important events in the life of Jesus Christ.
 - Christmas is the celebration of Jesus' birth, which is observed on December 25th.
 - Easter, on the other hand, is a celebration of Jesus' resurrection from the dead, which according to the Bible happened on the third day after his crucifixion. The date of Easter is determined by the lunar calendar and falls on a different date each year, typically between March and April.
 - Eg: Myth: **Bhekuli Biya or Banger Biye** arose from the myth that rain arises from the **croaking of frogs**.
 - In Assamese, '**Bhekuli**' means **frog** and '**Biya**' stands for **marriage**.
 - Likewise, in North East India's Tripura, it's called Banger Biye (Bang -Frog, Biye -Wedding).
 - The myth - According to the people of Assam, their ancestors have a poem which states that the farmers pray to the clouds and ask them why there is no rain? Then the clouds reply that if the frogs do not croak, then why will it rain?
 - Monsoon is the mating season of the frogs.
 - Hence if the frog croaks and calls his/her mate, then it rains.
 - That's how the croaking of the frog is associated with the rain.



- **Myths arose from Rituals: James Frazer (magical rituals)**
 - Against the intuitive idea that ritual reenacts myth or applies mythical theories, many 19th-century anthropologists supported the opposite position that **myth and religious doctrine result from ritual**. This is known as the "**primacy of ritual**" hypothesis.
 - The famous anthropologist Sir **James George Frazer** claimed that **myth emerges from ritual** during the natural process of religious evolution.
 - In **The Golden Bough** (1890; 1906-1915), Frazer famously argues that man progresses from belief in magic (and rituals based on magic), through belief in religion, to science.

- **Magic and rituals → Religion → Science.**
- When man gives up on belief in magic (ability to manipulate supernatural forces) and instead adopts religion (pleading, persuading, requesting to the supernatural forces), there are some rituals left without earlier associated magical mythologies.
- In other words, **when man loses his belief in magic, he justifies his formerly magical rituals by saying that they reenact myths or honor mythical beings.**
- **Eg: Gadhimai festival in Nepal (Ritual)**
Devotees believe the ritual slaughter brings good luck and encourage Gadhimai, the Hindu goddess of power, to answer their wishes. (myth)
- **Functionalist perspective:**
 - **Myth and ritual as non-coextensive: Malinowski**
 - Malinowski, on the other hand, saw myth and ritual as an integral part of the functioning of society. He argued that myths and rituals were not primitive or outdated, but rather served important social and psychological functions.
 - There are **rituals without associated myths**, and there are **myths without associated rituals**. Hence, myth and ritual are **NON-COEXTENSIVE**.
 - **Myths without Rituals:**
 - **Creation Myths:**
 - The Hindu tradition has various creation myths, such as the story of Brahma creating the universe. These myths are foundational to Hindu cosmology but may not necessarily be directly linked to specific rituals. The emphasis is on the narrative itself and its symbolic significance.
 - **Rituals without Myths:**
 - **Vratas (Vows) and Pujas (Worship):**
 - Certain Hindu rituals involve vratas and pujas that are performed for specific purposes, such as fulfilling a wish or seeking blessings. While these rituals are deeply ingrained in Hindu practice, they may not always have a detailed mythological story associated with them. The emphasis is on the performance of the ritual itself.
 - (Note: Did you realize that this position is the opposite of Robert Segel's statement in the beginning?)
 - Also, according to Malinowski, **myths have a function**. For instance, they function as fictitious accounts of the origin of rituals, thereby providing a **justification for those rituals**. Therefore, myth gives rituals a past story and thereby sanctions them.
 - Similarly, rituals too can have functions.

The study of **myths** and **rituals** shows that they are not just **primitive survivals** but **meaningful cultural practices**. Whether arising from each other or functioning **separately**, both play vital roles in **explaining the world, guiding behavior**, and **maintaining social unity**.

IV. Forms of Religion :

The study of religion in anthropology often begins with its earliest and simplest forms. Different scholars like **E. B. Tylor, Max Muller, Durkheim, and Herbert Spencer** explained how humans tried to make sense of the unknown by attaching meaning to nature, spirits, ancestors, or mysterious powers. These early forms of religion, such as **animism, naturalism, totemism, ancestor worship, animatism, fetishism, and taboos**, give us insight into how belief systems evolved and became more organized over time.

1. Animism:
2. Naturalism:
3. Totemism:
4. Ancestor worship:
5. Animatism:
 - a. Manaism:
 - b. Bongaism:
6. Fetishism
7. Taboo
1. **Animism:**

- **E B Tylor** asserted that the foundation of all religions is animism.
- In Latin **anima means soul**, and thus animism is **belief in soul**. It is the belief that not only living creatures but also inanimate objects have life.
- These supernatural forces are referred to as spirits, ghosts, or Gods.
- They are believed to be as people do.



- Such spirits may reside in plants, water, air, stones or in animals.
- E B Tylor in his book '**Primitive Culture**' (1871) shows the evolution of religion from Animism through Polytheism to monotheism.
- **Example:**
 - **The Kamars of Central India (studied by S. C. Dube)** believe that in dreams the soul leaves the body and wanders.
 - Meeting ancestors or spirits in dreams is taken as proof of the soul's existence.

2. Naturalism:

- **Max Muller** emphasized that the earliest form of religion must have been the naturalism or worship of nature.
- Thus, the primitive man was inspired by natural phenomena and without understanding it, he sought to explain it.
- According to this theory, the early man was surprised with **natural phenomena** such as sun rising and setting, thunder sending rain, etc.
- An attitude of love and reverence towards objects of nature was born as a result, and they started worshiping rivers, mountains, trees and other natural objects.
- Max Muller stresses the evolution of religion from **Naturalism** through polytheism and to the current stage of Monotheism.
- **Example:**
 - The Garo tribe of Assam worship the sun and moon.
 - The Munda people worship the sun god.

3. Totemism:

- *Totem* is an important characteristic of tribal religion.
- The *totem* is considered to be the **originator of a particular clan**.
- The killing and eating of which is a taboo for the people associated with the *totem*.
- It is worshiped and respected everywhere.
- **Example: Australian Aborigines**
 - They live in small bands.
 - Each band has a totem such as an animal, plant or some geographical element.
 - Each band is associated with a totem and believes that its ancestors have descended from that totem.
 - They neither kill nor eat the *totem*.
- **Emile Durkheim** argues that since the Australian aborigines are **most 'primitive'**, their belief in *totem* (*totemism*) must be the most elementary form of religion.
- (Refer to Totems and Clan from Kinship Handout where it has been covered in detail.)

4. Ancestor worship:

- The philosopher **Herbert Spencer** traced the origin of religion in reverence to ancestors.
- Ancestor worship combined with beliefs in ghosts and fairies is believed to be caused by dream experience.
- **Example: Mizos- Rih lake**
 - The **Mizo tribes of Mizoram** believe that the souls of the dead travel to the **Rih Dil (Rih Lake)** in Myanmar before reaching the land of the dead.
 - The lake is thus seen as a **sacred place connecting the living and their ancestors**.
 - People perform rituals and offerings there to honor ancestors, believing it ensures the well-being of both the dead and the living.
 - (For more details, refer to class slides).

5. Animatism:

- For **R R Marett**, Animatism was the most rudimentary form of religion.
- According to him, animatism refers to belief in some **impersonal mysterious power or impersonal supernatural force** behind every material object besides living beings.
- It is of 2 different forms.
 - **Manaism:**
 - According to animatistic beliefs, there is an impersonal mysterious power. **Melanesians and Polynesians call it mana**.
 - The power of *mana* can dwell in persons, places, animals, plants, and sometimes in inanimate objects.
 - Mana is thought to inhabit some objects but not others, some people but not others.
 - For instance,
 - Among the **Polynesians**, mana is like an invisible electricity that can pass from one person or object to another, so kings and chiefs were believed to carry such strong mana that even walking in their footsteps could harm commoners.



- **Bongaism:**

- Bonga is conceived by the **Central Indian Tribals** as a power that pervades all space.
- It is indefinite and impersonal.
- That is why it is believed to take any shape or form.
- They use the term **bonga** to designate this power and quality.
- The impersonal bonga uses the medium of dreams to foretell bad things.
- **Example:**
 - Among the **Ho tribes of Jharkhand**, bonga is seen as an unseen force that exists in everything, from people to hills, and explains why some individuals have more prestige or power than others. They worship **Sing Bonga (the Sun God)** as the creator and **Marangburu, the Hill Goddess**, for bringing rains, showing how this impersonal power also takes the form of personal deities.

6. Fetishism:

- A **fetish is an object believed to have supernatural powers, or in particular, a human-made object that has power over others.**
- Essentially, **fetishism is the attribution of inherent value, or powers, to an object.**
- Initially, the Portuguese developed the concept of the fetish to refer to the objects used in religious practices by West African natives.
- The word Fetish comes from the Portuguese *feitico* and this in turn from Latin *facticius*, "artificial" and *facere*, "to make").
- The concept was popularized in Europe in 1757, when _____ used it in comparing **West African religion** to the magical aspects of ancient Egyptian religion.
- Later, _____ employed the concept in his theory of the evolution of religion, wherein he posited fetishism as the earliest (most primitive) stage, followed by polytheism and monotheism

7. Taboo:

- Taboo is a Polynesian term that means **prohibited**.
- Thus, **taboo is a prohibition that prevents many activities**. Violation of a taboo is not considered a crime but a sin.
- Behind law, is the power of the state. But **behind a taboo is the sanction of religion**.
- Therefore, taboos are more strictly observed.
- Its non-observance is supposed to annoy God.
- Therefore, the society or the state may not punish the violator, but it pricks one's conscience.
- The power of taboo is more than that of law.
- The people do not so much fear law, but taboo.
- Eg: Oraons- women not allowed to touch plough, Todas- Women not allowed to enter Sacred dairy areas.

The various forms of religion reflect how human beings across cultures and times sought to explain the world, cope with uncertainty, and build social order. Whether it is the belief in **souls, nature, totems, mana, bonga, fetishes, or taboos**, each system shows the human attempt to connect with forces beyond ordinary life. Together, they highlight the **diversity of belief systems** and also their common role in giving meaning, stability, and guidance to societies.

Meaning and Definition of Magic:

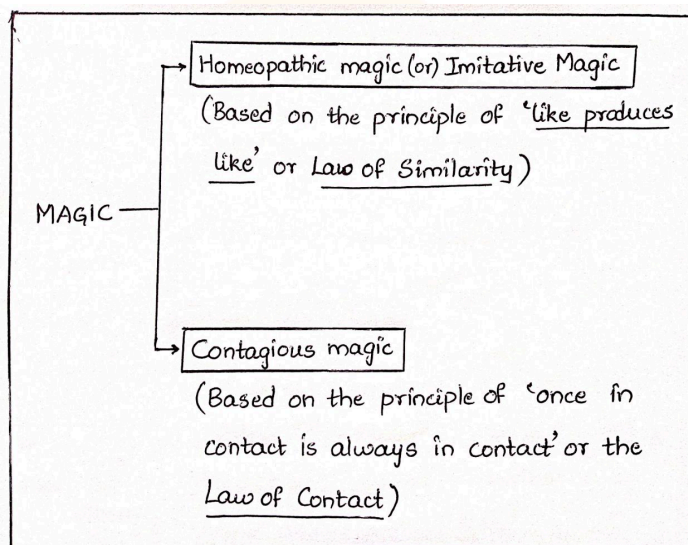
Magic has been studied by anthropologists as one of the earliest ways humans tried to control the forces of nature and deal with uncertainty. Thinkers like **James Frazer, Malinowski, and Firth** showed how magic is not random superstition, but a system of practices based on beliefs, symbols, and social needs.

- Sir **James George Frazer**, a leading British anthropologist is one of the first to define magic.
 - According to him **magic is the technique designed to achieve specific goals by manipulating the supernatural.**
- Frazer emphasized that magic is a technique, which involves certain skills for controlling the supernatural i.e., it includes certain actions that can **compel the supernatural** to achieve specific goals.
- **Malinowski** had witnessed magical practices among the '**Trobriand islanders**' and he describes it in his book '**Argonauts of Western Pacific**' 1922.
- He offered yet another definition of magic.
 - According to him, **magic consists of the superstitious acts and belief through which individuals try to control nature when their technology and rational techniques are insufficient.**
- For him, magic comes into existence when people try to **reduce their anxiety and uncertainty**.



James Frazer's Classification of magic:

- Sir James Frazer classified different magical practices into two forms on the basis of the laws or principles associated with those practices.
- He found that magical formulae are based on two principles:
- **Like produces like** or an effect resembles its cause, this is based on the **principle of Law of Similarity**
 - **How does rain occur?**
 - **Amongst the Mundas:**
 - They believe thunder causes rain, so they sacrifice animals and throw rocks down hills to mimic thunder, expecting rain.
 - **Amongst the Hos**
 - The Ho tribe lights fires, hoping rain will come from the smoke, displaying a form of homoeopathic magic.
 - **Amongst the Khonds**
 - The Khond tribe practiced human sacrifice, believing that tears and blood from the victim would bring rain.
- **Once in contact, always in contact**, is based on the '**Law of Contact**', the basic principle of this type of magic.
 - According to the Law of Contact, these items retain a connection with the person even after being separated. Consequently, these items can be used in magical practices to bring harm to the individual.
 - **Example:** In this type of magic, items like nail cuttings, hair trimmings, and bodily excretions are considered as parts of the person to whom they belonged.

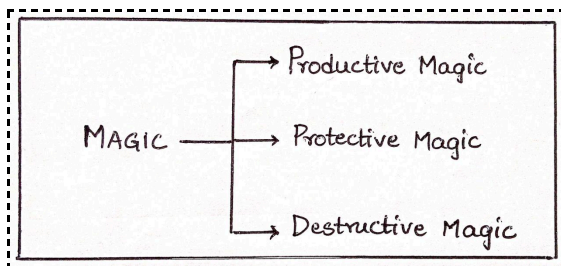


Other Classifications of Magic:

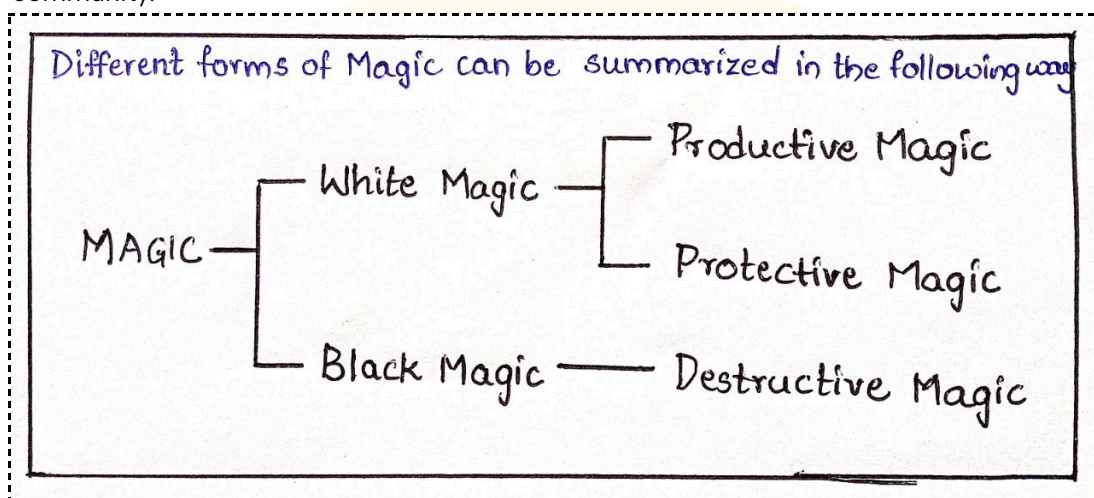
- Most anthropologists classify different magical practices into two distinct forms, namely
 - **Black magic**
 - **White magic.**
- This classification is made on the basis of the ends to be achieved.
- Black magic is used for destructive purposes.
 - **Example:** They might engage in black magic rituals or spells with the intention of causing illness, misfortune, or any form of harm to the targeted individual. The emphasis here is on negative and harmful outcomes.
- In contrast, white magic is employed with positive intentions. White magic is used for productive and protective purposes.
 - **Example:** Individuals practicing white magic may perform rituals or spells to bring about good fortune, healing, or protection. For instance, someone might use white magic to enhance their chances in a job interview or to safeguard their home from negative influences.

Firth's Classification of Magic:

- Raymond Firth classified different magical practices into three forms.
- These are based on the aims, the ends or the functions they serve.



- **Productive magic:**
 - Do good to the individual, group or community.
 - It includes **magic of hunting, magic of fertility, magic of rain making, magic of successful or abundant harvesting, magic of successful fishing** etc.
- **Protective Magic:**
 - Some other forms of magic protect individuals, groups or communities.
 - They are called protective magic.
 - Protective magic is used to **guard property, attain safety in travel, to counter sickness, to protect crops and cattle.**
 - All such protective magic is **socially approved.**
- **Destructive magic:**
 - Includes magic to destroy others' property, to produce sickness, to bring death, to create failure of crops and to **inflict any other harm** or destruction done to plants, individuals, groups or the whole community.



Firth's classification sheds light on how magical practices can be grouped based on their intended outcomes. Productive magic seeks to bring about positive results, protective magic aims to safeguard, and destructive magic is geared towards causing harm or destruction. These classifications help in understanding the diverse functions and cultural contexts of magical practices.

The study of magic shows that it is deeply tied to human attempts to overcome fear, uncertainty, and limits of knowledge. Whether **productive, protective, or destructive**, magical practices reveal how societies blend belief and action to make sense of the unknown and maintain balance in their lives.

Other Classifications of Magic:

- Some anthropologists have classified magic into sorcery and witchcraft.
- They treat both sorcery and witchcraft as destructive magic.
 - **Sorcery**
 - **Witchcraft**
- Refer to the topic- '**MAGICO-RELIGIOUS FUNCTIONARIES**' in this handout.

IV. Religion, magic and science distinguished:

Anthropologists like **E. B. Tylor**, **James Frazer**, and **Malinowski** have long studied how humans explain and control their world through **religion, magic, and science**. Each system has its own logic, yet all aim to address uncertainty in life.

Differences between Religion and Magic:

According to **Tylor**, religion is about building rapport with spirits or gods, while **Frazer** defined magic as techniques to control supernatural powers. In short, religion is faith-based, and magic is power-based.

- Religion and magic are the two basic techniques of dealing with the **supernatural**.
- Religion seeks spiritual rapport or is **subordinate to animistic beings**.
- Magic is a technique which **gains control over supernatural powers**.
- Some of the differences between religion and magic are given below:

Religion	Magic
Religion is public and communal.	Magic is confined to an individual.
Religion is characterized by diversified nature.	Magic is everywhere, uniform in its principles.
Religion is public and it has congregational aspects.	Magic is always secret in nature.
In religion, priests command respect in the society.	The magician is very much feared in the society.
Religion is commonly used for good purposes. It is considered as benevolent.	Magic is most commonly used for good and bad purposes. It is considered malevolent and harmful for society.
Religion is submissive in nature before the supernatural.	Magic controls supernatural forces to one's own favor.

Similarities between Religion and Magic:

Religion and magic share certain similarities in their nature and concerns, despite their distinct characteristics.

- **Non-Empirical Nature:**
 - **Characteristics:** Both religion and magic deal with non-empirical aspects, meaning their essence goes beyond what can be experimentally justified or proven through logic and scientific experimentation.
 - **Example:** In religious practices, concepts such as the divine, afterlife, and spiritual connection are non-empirical and transcend the boundaries of empirical observation. Similarly, magic, involving rituals and spells, operates in a realm beyond empirical verification.
- **Involvement with Supernatural Forces:**
 - **Commonality:** Both religion and magic are concerned with supernatural forces, acknowledging the existence of powers beyond the natural or observable world.
 - **Example:** In various religious traditions, the belief in deities, spirits, or other supernatural entities forms the basis of worship and spiritual practices. Similarly, magical practices often involve invoking or manipulating supernatural forces to achieve specific outcomes.
- **Taboos and Observances:**
 - **Shared Element:** Both religion and magic incorporate various taboos and observances into their practices.
 - **Example:** Religious ceremonies may include taboos related to cleanliness, specific dietary restrictions, or ritualistic observances during sacred times. Likewise, magical practices may involve adherence to certain taboos or observances believed to enhance the effectiveness of spells or rituals.

As **Malinowski** noted, both religion and magic reduce anxiety and help people cope with uncertainty, but their methods differ: one submits to divine will, the other seeks control.

Science:

- Science – according to _____ – is a **systematic endeavor** that builds and organizes knowledge in the form of **testable explanations** and predictions about the universe.
- The essence of science is the **scientific methodology**.
- It involves making **observations**, forming a **hypothesis**, conducting experiments to test the hypothesis, analyzing data, and drawing conclusions based on the results.
- In comparison to magic and religion, science is the latest stage of development in the sphere of human thought and action.



- Both science and magic are guided by **logical reason**, the former related with the **natural world** and the latter with the **supernatural world**.
- _____ called magic as '**pseudoscience**' or '**bastard sister of science**'

Differences between Science and Magic:

Frazer famously called magic the "bastard sister of science," since both are based on a cause-effect principle. Science tests this principle through experiments, while magic uses ritual and belief.

Some of the differences between Science and Magic are given below:

Science	Magic
Science is guided by reason and corrected by observation.	Magic is not guided by reasoning. It is considered as 'pseudo science', 'primitive science' or 'bastard sister of science' (Frazer)
Science is based on the conceptions of natural forces.	Magic is based on supernatural forces. It springs from the idea of a certain mystic, and impersonal power.
Science can be experimentally justified.	Magic cannot be experimentally justified.
Science is based on experiments.	Magic is based on belief and emotion.
Science is open to all, and generally for the common good of the society.	Magic aims for both good and bad purposes.

Similarities between Magic and Science:

Despite being distinct fields, magic and science share certain fundamental similarities, as highlighted by early and later anthropologists such as **Tylor, Frazer, Malinowski**, and others.

- Cause-Effect Relationship:**
 - Common Ground:** Both science and magic are based on the principle of a cause-effect relationship. They assert that a particular cause leads to a specific effect or outcome.
 - Example:** In science, if a certain chemical is introduced to a reaction, it will produce a predictable result. Similarly, in magical practices, a specific ritual or spell may be believed to cause a desired effect, establishing a cause-and-effect connection.
- Governing Principles:**
 - Shared Aspect:** Both science and magic operate under a set of principles that dictate the rules and conditions for achieving desired results.
 - Example:** Scientific principles guide researchers in conducting experiments and formulating hypotheses. Similarly, magical practices adhere to specific rules or rituals believed to influence the supernatural forces and bring about the intended outcomes.
- Orientation towards Goals:**
 - Common Objective:** Both science and magic are oriented toward achieving desired goals or outcomes, whether in the realm of the natural or the supernatural.
 - Example:** In scientific research, the goal might be to discover a new drug for a particular ailment. In magic, practitioners may aim to influence events, ensure good fortune, or protect against harm through specific rituals aligned with their goals.

Thus, science can be corrected by observation, but magic cannot. As **Malinowski** observed among the Trobriand Islanders, magic was used when practical knowledge ended, showing it as a precursor rather than an alternative to science.

Religion and Science:

Durkheim saw religion as a closed system of sacred beliefs, while **E. O. Wilson** (1999) defined science as an open, evolving system based on evidence. This contrast shows how they approach truth differently.

Religion	Science
Religion is a closed system of belief.	Science is an open system of thought.
Its beliefs are sacred.	The domain of science is profane.



They are not to be questioned; therefore they are not open to empirical testing.

The scientific facts undergo constant questioning and are subjected to empirical testing.

Religion and science represent two very different ways of understanding the world. They differ in their beliefs, methods, and openness to change.

1. Nature of Belief System

- **Religion:** A closed system of belief, with sacred and unalterable doctrines.
Example: Scriptures in Hinduism, Christianity, or Islam are treated as sacred truths and not open to questioning.
- **Science:** An open system of thought, always evolving with new evidence.
Example: The understanding of the solar system changed from a geocentric (Earth-centered) model to a heliocentric (Sun-centered) one as observations improved.

2. Sacredness of Beliefs

- **Religion:** Beliefs are sacred and unquestionable.
Example: Religious dogmas or tenets are expected to be accepted on faith without doubt.
- **Science:** The domain is profane (worldly), and theories are open to challenge and revision.
Example: Darwin's theory of evolution is constantly debated, tested, and refined with new findings in genetics and fossils.

3. Openness to Empirical Testing

- **Religion:** Beliefs are based on faith and are not subject to empirical testing.
Example: The existence of God or the afterlife lies beyond the scope of experiments or measurement.
- **Science:** Scientific facts are always tested, questioned, and validated through evidence.
Example: Laws of gravity or electromagnetism are repeatedly tested through experiments to ensure accuracy.

Religion provides **moral meaning and solidarity** (Durkheim), while science provides **testable knowledge and prediction** (Wilson). Both coexist in society but fulfill different human needs.

VI. MAGICO-RELIGIOUS FUNCTIONARIES (PRIEST, SHAMAN, SORCERER AND WITCH)

MAGICO-RELIGIOUS SPECIALISTS:

In every society, people depend on **magico-religious specialists** to deal with illness, uncertainty, and misfortune. **Malinowski (1922)** observed among the Trobriand Islanders that such figures reduce anxiety, while **Durkheim (1912)** emphasized that they also preserve social solidarity.

Magico-religious practices are performed by magico-religious specialists who intermediate between Human and supernatural beings.

• SHAMAN:

The **shaman**, described by _____ as the "master of ecstasy," is a part-time religious specialist who communicates with spirits through trance, dreams, or visions.

- A shaman is a religious specialist who devotes **part of his time to serve as an intermediary between individual and supernatural beings**. Both male and female shamans are found.
- He often works alone, since he applies his ability as an individual rather than a representative of a group.
- He learns to be a shaman from an elder shaman. He may **gain his abilities from direct contact with supernatural beings**.
- **Eg: Buryat shamans, Siberia**
- **Functions:**
 - Determine the **cause of illness and cure as well**.
 - **Acts as Healer or Medicine man (in America)**
 - People don't differentiate between illnesses of natural origin and supernatural origin. So, **shaman serves as medicine man (the term used in the Americas)**

Shamans are valued for healing and divination, especially where people see illness as both natural and supernatural.

- **MEDICINE MAN:** A medicine man (or woman) is a healer in indigenous cultures, often combining herbs, rituals, and spiritual powers.
 - In anthropology, a medicine man or woman is a **traditional healer** who practices **folk medicine** and **spiritual rituals**, often in indigenous societies.
 - A traditional healer and spiritual leader who **serves an Indigenous community of the Americas** is known as a **medicine man or medicine woman**. Each culture has its **own specific terms**, in their respective languages, for these types of spiritual healers and ceremonial leaders.
 - **Difference between Shaman and medicine man:**
 - According to _____, the term **shaman** is commonly used by non-Native anthropologists to refer to **indigenous healers worldwide**, including those in the



Americas. However, the term **shaman** specifically refers to **spiritual mediators from the Tungusic peoples of Siberia**, and is **not used in Native American or First Nations communities** to describe their traditional healers.

- **Functions:**

- Medicine men and women are believed to have **special healing powers** and are **respected members** of their community.
- They may use a variety of methods to heal, including **herbal remedies, rituals, and spiritual practices**.
- Some medicine men and women are also believed to be **able to communicate with spirits or the ancestors**, and may use this ability to diagnose and treat illness.
- While the role of medicine man or woman varies among different societies, they often play a central role in the **traditional healthcare system** of their community.

- **Case Study:**

- The **Ojibwe Native Americans** have a tradition called the **Midewiwin** (also spelled Midewin).
- The practitioners of this tradition are referred to as Midew, which translates to "**medicine man**" in English.
- The Midewiwin tradition is often associated with **spiritual healing** and the use of traditional practices and rituals to **promote health and well-being**.
- In the **Ojibwe culture**, Midew are **respected members** of the community who are believed to have **special powers to heal and communicate with spirits**.

They are respected custodians of both health and spirituality, as seen among the Ojibwe Midewiwin tradition.

- **PRIEST:**

A **priest** is a full-time religious specialist who represents a community in matters of faith and spirituality. Priests devote their entire time to the spiritual well-being of the group, perform rituals, and act as intermediaries between the divine and the community.

- **Key Characteristics:**

- **Full-Time Role:** Priests commit their lives entirely to spiritual service.
- **Community Support:** Priests are maintained and respected by the community for their role.
- **Training:** They undergo rigorous training in religious doctrines, rituals, and traditions.
- **Rituals:** Priests perform ceremonies and religious functions on behalf of the group.

- **Detailed Explanation:**

- 1. Representative Role**

- Priests serve as official representatives of their religious community and act as intermediaries between the group and the divine.
- *Example:* In **Catholicism**, a parish priest represents the congregation, conducts ceremonies, and offers guidance.

- 2. Community Support**

- Priests are supported by the community, both through respect and material means.
- *Example:* In **Hinduism**, temple priests conduct rituals like pujas and are supported through offerings and donations.

- 3. Full-Time Devotion**

- Priests dedicate their entire lives to spiritual service, unlike part-time specialists.
- *Example:* In **Buddhism**, monks often serve as priests, leading ceremonies and guiding devotees.

- 4. Training and Expertise**

- Priests undergo structured training within religious institutions, gaining mastery over doctrine and rituals.
- *Example:* In **Judaism**, rabbis study for years before becoming religious leaders who can guide their community.

- 5. Performance of Rituals**

- Priests perform essential rituals, ensuring that religious traditions are maintained.
- *Example:* In **Islam**, an imam leads prayers, conducts ceremonies, and provides spiritual guidance to the community.

Priests maintain religious continuity, order, and community identity, as seen in Hindu temple priests or Catholic parish priests.

- **SORCERER:**

A **sorcerer** is a person who practices **sorcery**, a form of magic usually associated with hostile or harmful practices. Unlike innate magical powers, sorcery is **acquired** through learning special techniques and rituals. Sorcerers are often feared in society and may occupy a lower social and economic status.



- **Key Characteristics**
 - **Hostile Magic:** Sorcery is commonly linked with harmful or destructive purposes.
 - **Acquired Skill:** Magical powers are learned through training, not inherited.
 - **Fearful Perception:** Sorcerers are feared because people believe they can bring harm.
 - **Low Social and Economic Status:** They are often marginalized and stigmatized.
- **Detailed Explanation:**
 1. **Nature of Sorcery**
 - Sorcery uses magical practices aimed at harming others.
 - *Example:* Casting curses, hexes, or spells to bring sickness or misfortune.
 2. **Acquisition of Skill**
 - Sorcery is a learned art, often through apprenticeship or training.
 - *Example:* In some societies, a person becomes a sorcerer by learning from an experienced practitioner.
 3. **Fear from the Public**
 - Sorcerers are deeply feared due to their perceived power to cause harm.
 - *Example:* In many societies, mere suspicion of sorcery can lead to social isolation or violence.
 4. **Social and Economic Status**
 - Sorcerers often face stigma and are pushed to the margins of society.
 - *Example:* In European history, people accused of sorcery or witchcraft were persecuted and sometimes executed.

Unlike priests or shamans, sorcerers are linked with suspicion and marginal status, showing how societies distinguish between benevolent and harmful powers.

- **WITCH:**

A **witch** is a person believed to practice **witchcraft**, a supernatural ability thought to be **inherent from birth**. Unlike sorcerers, who acquire skills through learning, witches are believed to possess an **innate and often unconscious power** to work both good and evil. Witchcraft is considered **inherited**, and witches are sometimes feared for their potential to harm others.

- **Key Characteristics**
 - **Inherent Power:** Witches are born with magical abilities.
 - **Inherited Trait:** Witchcraft is passed down through family lineage.
 - **Supernatural Activity:** Can perform both helpful and harmful acts using magic.
 - **Cultural Variations:** Different societies have unique beliefs and traits associated with witches.
- **Detailed Explanation:**
 1. **Inherent Nature of Witchcraft**
 - Witchcraft is viewed as an inborn capacity, present from birth.
 - *Example:* Folklore often describes certain families where witch powers are naturally passed on.
 2. **Inherited Ability**
 - Powers are thought to be transmitted across generations, forming a "witch lineage."
 - *Example:* A child born into a family of witches may automatically be believed to have magical powers.
 3. **Supernatural Activity**
 - Witches may use spells, charms, or rituals to heal or harm.
 - *Example:* A witch might be blamed for bringing illness, or alternatively, sought out for curing it.
 4. **Cultural Variations**

Beliefs about witches differ widely across cultures:

 - **India:** *Chudail* witches are believed to have feet pointing backward.
 - **Uganda:** *Ganda* witches are said to dance naked.
 - **Sudan (Dinka):** Witches are believed to have tails.
 - **Amba (Africa):** Witches are thought to hang upside down from trees and drink salt instead of water when thirsty.

Witches embody cultural fears of hidden, uncontrollable power, which explains why accusations of witchcraft often lead to social tension.

Practitioners and Social Complexity:

- Anthropologists have identified a pattern linking the type and number of practitioners with social complexity: **the more complex the society, the more the variety of magico-religious practitioners.**
- **One practitioner: (Shaman)**
 - **Foraging cultures** tend to have only one practitioner, a shaman.



- **Two practitioners: (Shaman and priest)**
 - If they are **agriculturalists, albeit without complex political and social organization**, then they generally have two practitioners, a shaman and a priest, chances are that they are agriculturalists, albeit without complex political and social organization.
- **Three practitioners: (Shaman, priests, and sorcerer/witch)**
 - **Agriculturalists and pastoralists with more complex political organization** that goes beyond the immediate community, generally have at least three types of practitioners, shamans, priests and a sorcerer, witch or medium.
- **All four practitioners: (Shaman, priests, sorcerers and witch)**
 - Cultures with **complex political organization**, agriculture, and complex social organization usually have all four practitioners

The variety of **magico-religious functionaries** reflects the complexity of society: simple foragers often rely only on shamans, while agrarian and state societies include priests, witches, and sorcerers alongside. As **Evans-Pritchard** reminds us, these roles cannot be dismissed as primitive; they are meaningful systems of explanation and social order within their cultural contexts.

Previous Year Questions

- Mention the characteristic features of a band with suitable examples. (15M/2017)
- How do political organizations of simple societies establish power, authority, and legitimacy? (20M/2021)
- Differentiate between State and Stateless Societies. (10M/2014)
- Authority and forms of political organization. (10M/2024)
- Discuss the mechanism of social control in different kinds of political systems. (20M/2022)
- How does customary law function in tribal society? Discuss its different sources. (15M/2018)
- Discuss the nature of Law and Justice in simple societies citing suitable examples. (20M/2014)
- Discuss the different traditional forms of religion in tribal societies. (2017)
- Critically explain the anthropological approaches to religion. (15M/2019)
- Totemism. (10M/2016)
- How does taboo serve as a means of social control? (15M/2013)
- Shaman, sorcerer, and medicine man. (10M/2022)
- Difference between Science and Magic. (10M/2018)
- Difference between religion and magic. (10M/2017)

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